Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Samuel

1 Samuel 1:1

- Elkanah was a Levite (a member of the tribe of Levi) (1 Chronicles 6:22–27). After the Israelites conquered the promised land, the Levites received towns in other tribes' territories, including Ephraim (Joshua 21:20).
- Elkanah's hometown was Ramah (1 Samuel 2:11). Do not confuse this Ramah with the one in the land of Benjamin (see Joshua 18:25; Judges 19:13; Matthew 2:18).
- The region of Zuph got its name from one of Elkanah's ancestors, a Levite from the Kohath clan (1 Chronicles 6:35). Saul first met Samuel in Zuph while looking for his father's donkeys (1 Samuel 9:5).
- Elkanah's long family history suggests he was important in society.

1 Samuel 1:2

In the Bible, when a man married two wives at the same time, it often led to serious conflict (1 Samuel 1:6–7; Genesis 16; 21; 29).

1 Samuel 1:3

- Elkanah made this trip every year because the law required people to attend three festivals a year (Exodus 23:14–17).
- According to God's law, Israelites had to sacrifice at God's chosen sanctuary (Deuteronomy 12:1–28). From the time of Joshua to Samuel, God's sanctuary, the tabernacle, was in Shiloh (Joshua 18:1). Shiloh was a town in Ephraim about 13.7 kilometers (8.5 miles) north of Bethel on the way to Shechem. King David later moved the tabernacle to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6).
- the LORD of Hosts: In the Hebrew Old Testament, God is often called Yahweh Tseba'oth or 'Elohim Tseba'oth. These titles are traditionally translated as "Lord of hosts" and "God of hosts."

The term "hosts" (Hebrew tseba'oth, traditionally "sabaoth") usually means "armies." It can refer to human armies, like the armies of Israel (for example, 1 Samuel 17:45). I can also refer to foreign armies sent to carry out the Lord's plans (for example, Isaiah 9:11–13). However, it most often refers to God's armies of angels sent from heaven to carry out his commands and fight on earth (for example, 2 Kings 6:17).
This title highlights God's role as a powerful warrior in the story involving the ark of the covenant and the Philistines (1 Samuel 4–6).

1 Samuel 1:4

Sacrifice ... portions [of the meat]: Some sacrifices included sharing part of the animal in a community meal (see Leviticus 7:11–34).

1 Samuel 1:7

the house of the LORD: This is another name for the tabernacle. It is also known as "the temple of the LORD" in 1 Samuel 1:9. These names show that the tabernacle, a portable building, was the main sanctuary in Shiloh.

1 Samuel 1:9

the temple of the LORD: This means the Lord's sanctuary. Solomon's Temple was not built yet, so temple here refers to the Lord's holy place.

1 Samuel 1:11

Hannah promised to dedicate her child to the Lord as a Nazirite (see Numbers 6:1–21). She might have hoped her child would be like Samson, a deliverer of God's people (compare Judges 13). A deliverer was someone who rescued the Israelites from their enemies

1 Samuel 1:13–14

Some people may have used the feast times at Shiloh to drink too much alcohol instead of worshiping. Eli wrongly thought Hannah was just another person who was drunk (see Acts 2:13–15).

1 Samuel 1:16

wicked woman (Hebrew a daughter of Belial): This phrase describes a worthless person. Belial means "worthlessness" and people later used it as a name for Satan (2 Corinthians 6:15). In Hebrew, a son of or daughter of a quality refers to someone who shows that quality strongly.

1 Samuel 1:17–18

A blessing was more than just wishful thinking. It was often God's way of giving a real benefit (see, for example, Genesis 27:1–40; 28:1–4; 32:22–32; 48:1–49:28). Because this blessing from God's high priest assured Hannah that her prayer would be answered, she was no longer sad.

1 Samuel 1:22

After the boy is weaned: Hannah likely nursed Samuel for two to four years.

1 Samuel 1:23

Elkanah could have canceled Hannah's promise (see Numbers 30:12–14). But he chose to affirm and support it instead.

1 Samuel 2:1

my horn is exalted: Literally has lifted my horn; see also 1 Samuel 2:10. The horn of a strong animal, like an ox or bull, was a symbol of strength. It was raised in victory after defeating an enemy (see also 1 Kings 22:11).

1 Samuel 2:1–10

Hannah's Prayer of Praise celebrates Samuel's dedication to serving God. It highlights God's:

- Uniqueness (1 Samuel 2:1–2)
- Power to change fortunes (1 Samuel 2:3–9)
- Ability to strengthen his chosen king (1 Samuel 2:10)

Like Mary's Song of Praise in Luke 1:46–55, Hannah's prayer emphasizes God bringing down the rich and powerful and lifting up the poor and oppressed (1 Samuel 2:7–8; Luke 1:52–53). David's prayer in 2 Samuel 22 is another beautiful statement of God's saving power for his chosen king (1 Samuel 2:10). God will bring down the rich, unrighteous rulers (like Eli, Saul, or Herod). Leaders who follow God's will like Samuel, David or Jesus will be lifted up to a higher position or status.

1 Samuel 2:2

- no one besides You: David reacted the same way after hearing God's promises about his kingship (2 Samuel 7:22).
- Rock (compare 2 Samuel 22:2–3, 32): God offers stability and security to those who trust in him.

1 Samuel 2:3

Do not boast so proudly, or let arrogance…: Peninnah showed this attitude (see 1 Samuel 1:6–7). In contrast, Hannah was humbly dependent on God. This means she did not think too highly of herself. Instead, she trusted in God and relied on him for help.

1 Samuel 2:4–8

Hannah celebrated God's power to completely change people's situations.

1 Samuel 2:5

- Those who were hungry now have enough to eat (see 1 Samuel 1:7, 18).
- The phrase seven children poetically means that a woman without children would be blessed with a home full of children (see 1 Samuel 2:21).

1 Samuel 2:7–8

Compare with Psalm 113:7–9.

1 Samuel 2:8

The entire earth belongs to the Lord. God, who created and rules everything, can:

- change circumstances (1 Samuel 2:4–8),
- protect those who are faithful (1 Samuel 2:9),
- judge those who are wicked, and
- give strength to his chosen king (1 Samuel 2:10).

1 Samuel 2:10

- The king was to use his God-given power to help the oppressed, the hungry, and those unable to have children (see Psalm 72:1 4, 12–14; Proverbs 31:8–9).
- He will exalt the horn: See study note on 1 Samuel 2:1.
- His anointed (Hebrew mashiakh): This part of Hannah's prayer predicts both Israel's anointed kings and God's ultimate Anointed King—the Messiah, Jesus Christ (see 1 Samuel 12:3–5; 24:6, 10; Psalm 132:17; Daniel 9:25–26).

1 Samuel 2:12

- wicked men (Hebrew sons of Belial): See study note on 1:16.
- had no regard for (literally did not know) the LORD: Even though they were priests among God's people, they ignored God and did not follow his will (compare Jeremiah 2:8).

1 Samuel 2:13–17

The priests were meant to take their share of the meat only after it was boiled (see Numbers 6:19). Eli's sons ignored God's rules (1 Samuel 2:13–14, 17).

1 Samuel 2:15

God's law stated that the fat from a sacrificial animal belonged to the Lord. The priests had to burn the fat on the altar before anything else could be done with the animal (Leviticus 3:3–17).

1 Samuel 2:18

- The phrase Samuel served the Lord refers to the religious duties of Levites and priests (see, for example, Numbers 3:4; 8:19, 24; Deuteronomy 18:7). Samuel, like Eli's sons, was a Levite (see study note

on 1 Samuel 1:1). However, unlike Eli's sons, Samuel performed his duties well.
- He wore a linen garment similar to what priests wore when serving in the sanctuary (see study note on 1 Samuel 22:18).

1 Samuel 2:20

Eli would bless: Blessing was one of the functions of a priest (Numbers 6:23–27; Deuteronomy 10:8; 1 Chronicles 23:13). See study note on 1 Samuel 1:17–18.

1 Samuel 2:22

- sleeping with the women: Eli's sons were likely influenced by Canaanite religious practices, which included sex as part of the ceremony.
- who served at the entrance: See Exodus 38:8.

1 Samuel 2:22–25

Eli's weak efforts to correct his the behavior of his sons (see 1 Samuel 2:29) show he raised them without discipline (1 Samuel 3:13).

1 Samuel 2:25

- God (or the judges; Hebrew 'elohim): The Hebrew word translated intercede is plural here. When 'elohim means "God" it often takes a singular verb. Some ancient translations interpret 'elohim as "judges" in this context. If so, the judges would mediate for the guilty in a human court. Yet, many Hebrew scholars argue that 'elohim should not be translated as "judges." If so, how could God intercede for the man who sinned? Eli might have believed that court decisions came directly from God. God might work through his written laws or through other events to either free or find guilty a person accused of doing something wrong. Or Eli might have been talking about the system of animal sacrifices.
- The sexual wrongdoing in (1 Samuel 2:22) and excessive eating in (1 Samuel 2:12–17) of Eli's sons were sins against the Lord. This was because they were corrupting how Israel worshiped God. No one can speak to God on behalf of sinners who completely refuse to follow God's will (see Matthew 12:31).
- Eli's sons ignored their father because the Lord had already started to punish them by making their hearts stubborn (see Exodus 4:21; 7:3; 8:15–32; 10:27; 11:10).

1 Samuel 2:26

As children, both Samuel and Jesus had extraordinary qualities (1 Samuel 2:21; see also Luke 2:40, 52). Samuel was one of Jesus' forerunners (someone who came before and prepared the way). Samuel showed what would happen to Jesus through his words, actions, and sometimes through events in his own life that were similar to what would happen in Jesus' life.

1 Samuel 2:27

"Man of God" is another name for a prophet (1 Samuel 9:6; 1 Kings 13:1; 2 Kings 1:9).

1 Samuel 2:29

Eli did not stop his sons from doing wrong, showing disrespect for God's sacrifices and offerings. Eli gained from their actions, so God blamed him for allowing it.

1 Samuel 2:30

that your house and the house of your father would walk before Me forever: See Exodus 29:9 and Numbers 25:13. God will honor another of Aaron's descendants (see study note on 1 Samuel 2:35) and reject Eli's family, removing them from the priesthood (1 Samuel 2:31–35).

1 Samuel 2:32–33

reach old age: In the Old Testament, a short life often shows God's disapproval. A long life shows God's blessing (see Genesis 15:15; 1 Kings 3:14; Psalm 91:16).

1 Samuel 2:35

a faithful priest: Zadok and his family later took over the priesthood from Eli's family (1 Kings 2:26–27, 35).

1 Samuel 3:1

the word of the LORD was rare, and visions were scarce: God was not revealing his will through prophets or priests. This means that God was not regularly speaking to his people or giving them guidance.

However, this time of spiritual darkness was about to end when God began to communicate with Samuel (1 Samuel 3:2–4:1a).

1 Samuel 3:2

Eli could barely see, both with his eyes and in his faith (1 Samuel 3:1).

1 Samuel 3:3

- The priests had to keep God's lamp burning all night (Exodus 27:20–21; 30:7–8).
- Samuel sleeping near the ark shows his closeness to God's presence and purpose, unlike Eli and his sons.

1 Samuel 3:7

Samuel did not yet know the LORD: This was because he had no direct experience with the Lord. In contrast, Eli's sons did not know the Lord because they were morally and spiritually lacking (see study note on 1 Samuel 2:12).

1 Samuel 3:8

Eli realized: Even with his flaws, Eli still had some spiritual insight.

1 Samuel 3:10

- Repeating the name highlights the importance of the moment (see Genesis 22:11; Exodus 3:4; Matthew 27:46; Luke 22:31; Acts 9:4).
- Samuel leaves out "Lord" (see 1 Samuel 3:9) in his reply, possibly out of respect for the name or because he was unsure who was speaking.

1 Samuel 3:11

something in Israel at which the ears of all who hear it will tingle: This phrase shows how serious God's judgment is. God's actions would also have a major impact on Israel as a nation (see 2 Kings 21:12; Jeremiah 19:3).

1 Samuel 3:12

Everything I have spoken: See 1 Samuel 2:27–36.

1 Samuel 3:13

- because his sons blasphemed God: They showed contempt for God through their actions.
- he did not restrain them: Eli scolded his sons (1 Samuel 2:23–25), but he did not stop them.

1 Samuel 3:14

Blood sacrifices and offerings would not be accepted for Eli and his sons. The offerings in Leviticus 4–5 were for accidental or unintentional sins. But Eli and his sons sinned on purpose and rebelliously.

1 Samuel 3:15

Samuel was scared to tell Eli about God's plans for him and his family. He either respected Eli's position or feared for his own safety.

1 Samuel 3:19

He let none of Samuel's words fall to the ground: Samuel was a true prophet, as shown in 1 Samuel 3:20 and Deuteronomy 18:21–22.

1 Samuel 3:20

- The entire nation, from Dan in the north to Beer-sheba in the south, recognized Samuel as God's prophet.
- confirmed as a prophet: Samuel's reliable messages (1 Samuel 3:19) showed that God spoke through him.

1 Samuel 3:21–4.1

- the LORD continued to appear: God started talking to Israel again through Samuel (see 1 Samuel 3:1).
- Shiloh: Refer to study note on 1 Samuel 1:3.

1 Samuel 4:1

- the Philistines: See "The Philistines" Profile.
- The exact location of Ebenezer is unknown. It was likely just east of Aphek (see also 1 Samuel 7:12 and 1 Samuel 7:12).
- Aphek was west of Shiloh, far inland and north of Philistine territory. By camping there, the Philistines might have been trying to take more Israelite land.

1 Samuel 4:1–7.2

The crisis with the ark of the covenant showed Israel needed Samuel's leadership. It also fulfilled prophecies about Eli and his sons (1 Samuel 3:11–14).

1 Samuel 4:3

The Israelites were often defeated in war because of the sin of one individual or the entire nation (Joshua 7). In this defeat, no one checked if sin was the reason. It seems no one asked the Lord if they should fight the Philistines in the first place (see 1 Chronicles 14:13–16). Instead, the Israelites used the ark, the most sacred symbol of the Lord's presence, as a way to bring good luck. Bringing the ark into battle was not always wrong (see Joshua 6:2–21), but it did not guarantee God's blessing and victory.

1 Samuel 4:4

- the LORD of Hosts: See study note on 1 Samuel 1:3.
- enthroned between the cherubim: This represents God's glorious presence above the ark in the Most Holy Place (God's "throne room").
- Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, being involved signals the disaster to come (see 1 Samuel 3:11–14).

1 Samuel 4:6–7

Like the Israelites, the Philistines saw the ark as a powerful charm (see 1 Samuel 4:2–3). They believed it would lead to their defeat in battle.

1 Samuel 4:8

- the gods who struck the Egyptians: The Philistines, who worshiped many gods, knew about the Lord's power. However, they did not understand that he was the one true God.
- Struck ... with all kinds of plagues: The Lord later demonstrated his power against the Philistines in a similar way (see 1 Samuel 5:6–6:6).

1 Samuel 4:10

30,000 was over seven times the number who had died before without the ark (1 Samuel 4:2). The Israelites learned that the ark was not a magical object to prevent bad luck.

1 Samuel 4:11

- The capture of the ark was a huge blow to the Israelites (1 Samuel 4:12–22).
- The deaths of Hophni and Phinehas fulfilled God's promise to Eli (1 Samuel 2:34). Although they are the only ones mentioned, other Israelites had also sinned (see 1 Samuel 7:3–6).

1 Samuel 4:12

his clothes torn and dirt on his head: This shows grief and loss (for example, Joshua 7:6; 2 Samuel 1:2; 15:32; Job 2:12).

1 Samuel 4:15

could not see: See 1 Samuel 3:2 and study note on 1 Samuel 3:2.

1 Samuel 4:18

- Eli fell backward: This was possibly from shock or a heart attack when he heard the message. His deadly fall represents his family's loss of the priesthood and the end of the wrongdoing his sons started (1 Samuel 2:12–17).
- Eli had judged Israel: Being a priest and a judge was possible at the same time (compare Exodus 18:13–26; Deuteronomy 17:8–13). Samuel took over as Israel's judge and provided the leadership Eli did not (see 1 Samuel 7:12–17).
- The phrase forty years connects Eli's career to the timeline and themes of the book of Judges (compare Judges 3:11; 5:31; 8:28; 13:1).

1 Samuel 4:20–21

The name Ichabod includes the Hebrew word kabod, meaning glory (see Exodus 24:15–17). A similar word describes Eli in 1 Samuel 4:18 (Hebrew kabed, meaning heavy). The ark's disappearance mirrors the fall of Eli's family. The Israelites lost divine glory and protection (compare Ezekiel 8–10; Luke 19:41–44; 21:20–24), but God's glorious presence would later return to them (1 Samuel 6:1–21; compare Ezekiel 43:1–8).

1 Samuel 5:1

- Ebenezer: See study note on 1 Samuel 4:1b.
- Ashdod was one of the five main Philistine cities (see 1 Samuel 6:17). It was on the same major trade route (the Great Trunk Road) as Aphek.

1 Samuel 5:2

Dagon was a god worshipped by the Philistines (see Judges 16:23–24). The name might come from the Hebrew word dag, which means "fish." This would be an appropriate name for a god of seafaring people. However, it is more likely related to the Hebrew word dagan, which means "grain." This would indicate a god of fertility or agriculture.

1 Samuel 5:4

his head and his hands broken off: This was a symbol of God's power over the idol (1 Samuel 5:7; see also 17:51).

1 Samuel 5:5

step on the threshold: The Philistines might have thought Dagon's statue broke because they did not honor him correctly. However, their real mistake was worshiping an idol instead of the one true God (Isaiah 44:6–20).

1 Samuel 5:6

tumors: The Hebrew word might just mean "swellings." Another possible translation is "hemorrhoids." They could have been deadly buboes from the bubonic plague, affecting the lower body, especially the rectal area. Rats are known to carry the plague.

1 Samuel 5:8

- rulers (or overlords): Each of the five major Philistine cities had its own ruler (1 Samuel 6:16–18).
- It must be moved: Even with the clear danger, the Philistines valued their captured trophy so much that they chose to move it instead of returning it.
- Gath, one of the five major Philistine cities, was close by.

1 Samuel 5:9

God often caused great panic to disable and overpower Israel's enemies (1 Samuel 14:15, 20; Deuteronomy 7:23; Ezekiel 22:5; Amos 3:9).

1 Samuel 5:10

Ekron, one of the five main Philistine cities (see 1 Samuel 6:17), was only five miles north of Gath.

1 Samuel 6:2

priests and diviners: Fortune telling was part of the Philistine religion (see 1 Samuel 28:7; Deuteronomy 18:10–14).

1 Samuel 6:3

The Philistines probably did not know about Israelite worship rules. A Philistine guilt offering was likely a payment to their god. It was to avoid his anger. This differs from the idea of atonement in Leviticus 16.

1 Samuel 6:4

rats: See study note on 1 Samuel 5:6.

1 Samuel 6:6

The Philistines believed they could defeat the Lord by fighting harder (1 Samuel 4:9). They had beaten the Israelites, but now understood they could not defeat Israel's God.

1 Samuel 6:7

take their calves away: If the cows ignored their motherly instincts and left their calves to take the Ark to Israel, it would show that the plague came from Israel's God (1 Samuel 6:9).

1 Samuel 6:9

Beth-shemesh was the nearest Israelite town to Ekron (a Philistine city) (1 Samuel 5:10).

1 Samuel 6:13

People usually harvested wheat in May or June (late spring or early summer).

1 Samuel 6:14

This burnt offering might have been for forgiveness of sin (see 1 Samuel 7:9–10; Leviticus 1:3–17). But, it was more likely a voluntary act of love or gratitude (see Leviticus 22:18–22).

1 Samuel 6:15

Fortunately, the ark arrived in Beth-shemesh (1 Samuel 6:13), a city of the Levites (Joshua 21:13–16). The Levite men living there could safely move the ark (see Numbers 4:15).

1 Samuel 6:17

- guilt offering: See study note on 1 Samuel 6:3.
- Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron: These were the five main Philistine cities. They were on or near the Great Trunk Road, an important ancient trade route. This route connected Egypt with Mesopotamia through the coastal plain of Canaan. Each city had a ruler similar to a king (1 Samuel 6:16).

1 Samuel 6:19

- seventy men: Beth-shemesh was a small village.
- because they looked inside the ark: Touching the ark was not allowed (Numbers 4:15; 2 Samuel 6:6–8), as was looking inside it (Numbers 4:20). The men who died did not respect God's holiness.

1 Samuel 6:20

- Who can stand: Even God's people faced his wrath when they disrespected his holiness. The wrath of God is God's strong disapproval of human beings and their sinful actions.
- To whom should the ark go up from here?: When confronted with God's holiness, the Israelites felt the same distress as the pagan Philistines (1 Samuel 6:2).

1 Samuel 6:21

Kiriath-jearim was close, about 16 kilometers (10 miles) northeast of Beth-shemesh.

1 Samuel 7:1

- The men of Kiriath-jearim who moved the ark and Eleazar were likely Levites (see 1 Samuel 6:15; Numbers 1:47–51).
- to guard the ark: The same verb describes the Levites' duty to guard the tabernacle (Numbers 1:53; 3:7).

1 Samuel 7:2

Twenty years passed until Samuel gathered the people at Mizpah (1 Samuel 7:5–6). Later, David moved the ark to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6:1–19).

1 Samuel 7:3

- People cannot expect God's blessing unless they remove what goes against his will (see Genesis 35:2; Joshua 24:14).
- Ashtoreth was the Canaanite goddess of fertility linked to Baal (1 Samuel 7:4). Worshiping Canaanite gods was a constant issue in Israel's history. The people began idol worship during the twenty years in 1 Samuel 7:2. It may have started in the time of

the judges (1 Samuel 8:8; Judges 6:25; compare Amos 5:25–26). Israel's crushing defeat by the Philistines was not only due to the sins of Eli's two sons but also several generations of unfaithfulness to God.

1 Samuel 7:3–10

Israel's victory over the Philistines was due to their improved relationship with God, not because of the ark's presence (see 1 Samuel 4:3–11).

1 Samuel 7:5

- Mizpah was a government center and gathering place for the nation (see 1 Samuel 7:16; 10:17; Judges 20:1).
- I will pray ... on your behalf: Eli's question in 1 Samuel 2:25 is answered here; Samuel was the mediator Israel needed.

1 Samuel 7:6

- drew water ... poured it out: This ceremony is not mentioned elsewhere in the Old Testament.
- Sometimes, Israelites fasted (did not eat) to show grief or seek the Lord's favor (2 Samuel 1:12; 12:22–23; 1 Kings 21:27; Ezra 8:21–23; Nehemiah 9:1; Esther 4:3, 16; Joel 2:12; compare Luke 2:37; Acts 13:2–3; 14:23).
- Having Samuel as Israel's judge was refreshing compared to Eli's poor leadership (see 1 Samuel 4:18 and 1 Samuel 4:18) and the leadership of some other judges, for example:
- Gideon (Judges 8:22–27)
- Jephthah (Judges 11:30–12:7)
- Samson (Judges 13:1–16:21)

1 Samuel 7:9

- The whole burnt offering was likely for forgiveness of sin (see Leviticus 1:1–4).
- The Lord responded with a loud thunderclap (1 Samuel 7:10).

1 Samuel 7:10

thundered loudly: See 1 Samuel 2:10. God often used thunder to confuse and defeat Israel's enemies (for example, Exodus 14:24; 23:27; Joshua 10:10; Judges 4:15).

1 Samuel 7:12

Ebenezer: We do not know where this stone memorial is located. The Philistines had defeated Israel and taken the ark at a place with the same name (1 Samuel 4:1; 5:1). Samuel set up this memorial to honor God's help in reversing the Philistine attacks.

1 Samuel 7:13

- The Philistines remained inactive for a while, until Saul became king (see 1 Samuel 13:5).
- God's powerful intervention, not Samuel's talents, was crucial in freeing Israel from the Philistines.

1 Samuel 7:14

The Amorites lived in Canaan and the region east of the Jordan River before Israel took over the promised land (see Genesis 15:16; Deuteronomy 3:8; Joshua 2:10). Some Amorites stayed in the region after the conquest (see 2 Samuel 21:2).

1 Samuel 7:15

judged Israel all the days of his life: After Saul became king (1 Samuel 10), Samuel mainly served as a judge, not a military leader.

1 Samuel 7:16

- Bethel and Mizpah were places where people gathered during the time of the judges (Judges 20:1, 18, 26; 21:1–2). This was the time in Israel's history after the death of Joshua and before the beginning of the monarchy (when kings ruled). During this time, God raised up judges to lead and deliver Israel. Bethel was important even in Abraham's time (Genesis 12:8; 13:3–4; 28:10–22; 35:1–15).
- Gilgal, near Jericho, was a holy place since Joshua's time (Joshua 4:19–24; 5:2–10). From these places, Samuel guided "all the people of Israel" (1 Samuel 10:17).

1 Samuel 7:17

Samuel was from Ramah (see 1 Samuel 1:1).

1 Samuel 8:1–12.25

When Israel was changing to a monarchy (rule by kings), neither God (1 Samuel 8:7–9) nor Samuel (1 Samuel 12:1–25) liked the people's request for a king. Saul, the first king (1 Samuel 9–11), did not succeed in his role (1 Samuel 13–31) and proved Samuel's warnings true (see 1 Samuel 8:10–18; compare 1 Samuel 16:1–13).

1 Samuel 8:2

Samuel's two oldest sons served as judges in Beersheba, which is 80.5 kilometers (50 miles) south of their father's home.

1 Samuel 8:3

his sons did not walk in his ways: They were more like Eli's two sons (1 Samuel 2:12–17). Their corruption was a main reason the time of the judges ended.

1 Samuel 8:5

- you are old, and your sons do not walk in your ways: Judges were usually local leaders. But kings, as national leaders, could unite the entire nation during crises (1 Samuel 8:20). However, a spiritual issue was behind the request for a king (1 Samuel 8:7–8).
- Other nations, like Egypt and Sumer, were ruled by kings for nearly 2,000 years before Samuel's time.

1 Samuel 8:6

Samuel was unhappy. He likely felt personally rejected (1 Samuel 8:7).

1 Samuel 8:7

- Listen to the voice of the people: God rarely told a prophet to listen to the misguided people. The people's desires and God's will would align with King David (see 2 Samuel 7:8–17).
- they have rejected Me: By rejecting judges, they were actually rejecting God's rule and authority (see also 1 Samuel 12:1–17).

1 Samuel 8:8

serving other gods: The people's request for a king showed a lack of trust in God. They wanted a human ruler to give them security instead of relying on God as their king. Because of this, Israel's monarchy was a divine concession (something God allowed), not a divine gift. Any king or human institution becomes idolatrous when people trust it more than they trust God.

1 Samuel 8:10–18

These verses explain why being a king has downsides. Each sentence describes something the king would take. A king would seize things, not just protect them.

1 Samuel 8:11

The people wanted a king to lead them, but Samuel warned that the king would control them. They asked for a leader but got a ruler.

1 Samuel 8:12–17

The king would take both people and their belongings.

1 Samuel 8:15

People had to give a tenth of their harvest as a sacred donation to support God's temple and its workers (Deuteronomy 12:6, 17–18; 14:22–29; 26:12–15). The king also required another tenth, which was a heavy burden due to the unpredictable nature of farming.

1 Samuel 8:17

you yourselves will become his slaves: By asking for a king, the people whose ancestors were once slaves in Egypt risked becoming enslaved again (see 1 Kings 12:1 20).

1 Samuel 8:18

The people would plead for relief, just like their ancestors did in Egypt under a harsh ruler (see Exodus 3:7).

1 Samuel 8:20

- God had set Israel apart from other nations (Leviticus 20:26; Numbers 23:9). By wanting a king and wishing to be like other nations, they were rejecting God's plan (see 1 Samuel 8:5–7; compare Deuteronomy 17:14).
- to judge us, to go out before us, and to fight our battles.": Kings had three main roles:

1. waging wars, both offensive and defensive,
2. enforcing laws, and
3. ensuring economic stability.

1 Samuel 8:21

repeated them in the hearing of the LORD: A prophet's role included presenting the people's concerns to God (see Numbers 27:5).

1 Samuel 8:22

Appoint a king for them: See study note on 1 Samuel 8:7; compare with Romans 1:24–26.

1 Samuel 9:1

a powerful man, whose name was Kish: Saul came from a wealthy family.

1 Samuel 9:1–11.15

Saul became powerful through three main events:

1. Samuel secretly anointed him (1 Samuel 9:1–10:16).
2. He was chosen by casting lots (1 Samuel 10:17–27).
3. He defeated the Ammonites (1 Samuel 11:1–15).

See also study note on 1 Samuel 13:1–16:13.

1 Samuel 9:2

Saul's looks, choice and handsome, without equal among the Israelites, made people loyal to him (see 1 Samuel 10:23; compare 16:12; 2 Samuel 14:25–26).

1 Samuel 9:5

Zuph, likely in Ephraim, was where Samuel came from (1 Samuel 1:1). God guided Saul to this place.

1 Samuel 9:6

The phrase man of God referred to a prophet (see 1 Samuel 2:27; also Deuteronomy 33:1; Joshua 14:6; 1 Kings 13:1–32).

1 Samuel 9:7

no gift to take to the man: It was common to bring a gift when asking for a prophet's help (see 1 Kings 14:2–3; 2 Kings 5:5, 15; 8:8). Some false prophets asked for gifts in exchange for their services (Micah 3:11). Saul's concern might show a misunderstanding, thinking he could buy advice from a prophet of God (Acts 8:20).

1 Samuel 9:12

- Community leaders usually met for business at the town gates (see Ruth 4:1–2).
- have a sacrifice on the high place: Samuel is one of the few people who combined prophetic and priestly roles (others include Moses, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Jesus).
- the high place: An open-air altar or platform on a hill near the city gate. High places often became sites for pagan idolatry (see Numbers 33:52; 1 Kings 15:14; 22:43; 2 Kings 12:3; 14:4; 15:4, 35).

1 Samuel 9:13

- To eat: During worship, part of a sacrifice was burned on the altar. The rest was eaten in a ceremonial feast by the guests (see also 1 Samuel 1:4).
- To bless the food: As a Levite, Samuel's role as a priest included offering blessings (see Deuteronomy 10:8; 21:5).

1 Samuel 9:16

- God's command to anoint Saul (by pouring olive oil on his head) marked his rise in status and dedication for a special purpose (see Exodus 30:22–33; Leviticus 8:12; 1 Kings 19:16; Isaiah 45:1).
- he will save them: As they had asked for (1 Samuel 8:20; compare Judges 13:5). David eventually defeated the Philistines (2 Samuel 5:17–25; 8:1; 21:15, 18–22).
- their cry has come to Me (compare Exodus 3:7–9): The Philistines were again trying to conquer Israel and make them pay tribute as subjects.

1 Samuel 9:21

- the smallest tribe: Saul tried to downplay Benjamin's importance, but they were strong warriors (Judges 20:14–31; see study note on 1 Samuel 10:17). What better tribe to lead in battle?
- least of all the clans: See 1 Samuel 9:1.

1 Samuel 9:25

A typical house had a flat roof used for many purposes, like sleeping during warm weather (see Deuteronomy 22:8; 2 Kings 4:10).

1 Samuel 10:1

- Samuel did this again by anointing David with olive oil (1 Samuel 16:13).
- The people of Israel belonged to the Lord, not the king. The king was to manage, not own, them (compare 1 Samuel 8:10–18).

1 Samuel 10:2

Rachel's tomb in Zelzah: See Genesis 35:16–20; the exact location is not known.

1 Samuel 10:2–6

These three "signs" were meant to convince a hesitant Saul (1 Samuel 9:21) that he was truly chosen to be king.

1 Samuel 10:3

- Oak of Tabor: This place is in Benjamin and should not be mixed up with the village named Tabor in Zebulun (1 Chronicles 6:77).
- Bethel: See study note on 1 Samuel 7:16.

1 Samuel 10:5

- Gibeah of God, Saul's hometown (1 Samuel 10:26), was once a lawless city (Judges 19–21). It is not described elsewhere as "of God." This might suggest God's claim over the town, even though the Philistines occupied it.
- group: Prophets often lived in groups (for example, 2 Kings 2:3)
- harps ... lyres: Ancient prophets sometimes used musical instruments to inspire and support their prophesying (for example, 2 Kings 3:15).

1 Samuel 10:6

- prophesy: See 2 Samuel 23:2 and Acts 2:29–31.
- different person: Saul would become a spiritual and charismatic national leader (see 1 Samuel 16:14).

1 Samuel 10:7

God is with you: This refers to God giving Saul the strength to do his duties.

1 Samuel 10:8

- Gilgal: See the study note on 1 Samuel 7:16.
- Wait seven days: Saul seems to have followed this instruction in 1 Samuel 11:14–15 (compare with 13:8).

1 Samuel 10:9

God changed Saul's heart: God gave Saul courage and strength, helping him overcome his doubts and become king (1 Samuel 10:6).

1 Samuel 10:10

- the Spirit of God rushed upon him: See "The Spirit's Presence" Theme Note; also see 1 Samuel 11:6; Judges 14:6, 19; 15:14; compare Acts 2:17–18, 39).
- When Saul began to prophesy, it clearly showed he was chosen to lead Israel (see also 1 Samuel 19:18–23).

1 Samuel 10:11

People who knew Saul might have thought he was not religious, making him an unlikely choice for a prophet. They might have been surprised and disappointed to get a prophet instead of a king (see John 6:14–15).

1 Samuel 10:12

"And who is their father?" So the saying became a proverb: "Is Saul also among the prophets?" Unlike priests and kings, prophets did not inherit their role. People might wonder why Saul, with a wealthy, famous father, would join a group with no notable background.

1 Samuel 10:16

Saul might not have told his uncle because he was still unsure about what happened.

1 Samuel 10:17

An earlier generation had gathered at Mizpah to nearly destroy the tribe of Benjamin (Judges 20:1–4). This made Mizpah an ironic place to begin the reign of a king from the tribe of Benjamin.

1 Samuel 10:18

rescued you from ... all the kingdoms: Israel did not need a human king to save them. They needed God, but they rejected him (1 Samuel 10:19).

1 Samuel 10:19

- rejected your God: See also 1 Samuel 8:7. Israel did not trust God to protect and save them.
- Clans are smaller groups within tribes.

1 Samuel 10:20

was selected: See Leviticus 16:8; Joshua 18:6; 1 Chronicles 26:12–16; Acts 1:26.

1 Samuel 10:25

- rights of kingship: See Deuteronomy 17:14–20.
- He wrote them: Compare Exodus 24:4; Joshua 24:26.
- Samuel placed the document before the Lord, likely in the tabernacle. This act showed that God would reward those who followed the covenant and punish those who broke it.

1 Samuel 10:26

whose hearts God had touched: God gave them confidence in Saul's ability to lead (see also 1 Samuel 10:9).

1 Samuel 10:26–11.13

Saul showed he could lead by handling opposition and saving the town of Jabesh-gilead.

1 Samuel 10:27

- These men were wicked (see 1 Samuel 2:12) because they disrespected God's chosen king.
- People gave gifts to show respect (Genesis 32:13, 18, 20), build political friendships (2 Kings 20:12), or show submission (Judges 3:15, 17).
- Saul remained silent about it: His calmness when insulted showed maturity. In contrast, Proverbs 16:14 warns about a king's anger when challenged. See also 1 Samuel 11:12–13.
- One Dead Sea Scrolls manuscript includes this additional paragraph that is not found in the Berean Standard Bible:

"Nahash, king of the Ammonites, had viciously oppressed the people of Gad and Reuben, gouging out the right eye of each Israelite dwelling there. He would not allow anyone to rescue them, and there was no Israelite east of the Jordan whose right eye had not been gouged out. But 7,000 men had escaped from the Ammonites and settled in Jabesh-gilead" (see the marginal note on 1 Samuel 10:27 in the Berean Stan-

dard Bible).
Whether this material was part of the original text is uncertain. However, it helps explain the background of the conflict between Nahash and Jabesh-gilead and gives historical context for 1 Samuel 11:1–15 (for example, 1 Samuel 11:2).

1 Samuel 11:1

- Ammon (see Genesis 19:38), located east of the Jordan River, was a threat to Israel like the Philistines in the southwest (see also Judges 10:6–11:33).
- Make a treaty with us: Compare Joshua 9; 2 Samuel 10:19.

1 Samuel 11:1–15

Saul became king after winning a battle, which was why the people wanted a king (1 Samuel 8:20).

1 Samuel 11:2

put out everyone's right eye: In the ancient Near East, it was common to mutilate captured soldiers. These soldiers, with one eye, lost depth perception, making it hard for them to fight in a revolt.

1 Samuel 11:3

Nahash agreed to a seven-day delay, showing his arrogant confidence in winning and his desire to humiliate Israel as much as possible.

1 Samuel 11:7

Not participating would indicate rejection of the leadership of both Saul as king and Samuel as prophet.

1 Samuel 11:8

- Bezek was around 22.5 kilometers (14 miles) west of Jabesh-gilead.
- The narrator's use of the terms Israel and Judah hints at the later division of the kingdom (1 Kings 12).

1 Samuel 11:13

No one shall be put to death: This was a time to celebrate, not seek revenge.

1 Samuel 11:14

renew the kingship: "Renew" indicates something was damaged or worn out and is now being restored (see Psalm 51:10). The troublemakers (1 Samuel 10:27; 11:12) may have shaken the people's confidence, but Saul's victory over the Ammonites fixed that.

1 Samuel 11:15

- The formal ceremony before the Lord recognized Saul as king, while affirming that the Lord was Israel's true King.
- People often made peace offerings during important events that started significant institutions (see Exodus 24:5; Leviticus 9:4, 18, 22; 1 Kings 8:63–64).

1 Samuel 12:1–25

The confirmation of Saul as king at Gilgal was the last step in making him king (1 Samuel 11:12–15). It was also a suitable time for Samuel to give his farewell speech as Israel's leader.

1 Samuel 12:3

- God chose Saul as the anointed one (see 1 Samuel 9:16).
- Whose ox or donkey have I taken?: Compare with Numbers 16:15.
- Whom have I cheated or oppressed?: This contrasts with the actions of kings (1 Samuel 8:11–16).
- have I accepted a bribe and closed my eyes?: No, but Samuel's sons did (1 Samuel 8:3).

1 Samuel 12:5

you have not found anything in my hand: Samuel's life and leadership in Israel were beyond criticism (see 1 Corinthians 9:1–14; 2 Corinthians 7:2; 11:7–9; 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12). Saul, David, and Solomon, who were kings instead of prophetic judges, could not make this claim.

1 Samuel 12:6

Moses and Aaron did not become leaders on their own. God appointed them as leaders.

1 Samuel 12:6–25

In 1 Samuel 12:1–5, Samuel examined himself and was found innocent. In 1 Samuel 12:6–25, he examined the nation and found it guilty.

1 Samuel 12:9

- sold them into the hand: See Judges 3:8; 4:1–3.
- the king of Moab: See Judges 3:12. Not all of Israel's enemies during the time of the judges are listed (for example, the Ammonites and Midianites). This list highlights the significant events of that time.

1 Samuel 12:10

- Then they cried out to the LORD: Sometimes suffering is what turns people's hearts toward God. During

the time of the judges, Israel often went through cycles of sin, oppression, repentance, and rescue.
- Baals and Ashtoreths: When people turn away from God, they often turn to idols (see 1 Samuel 7:3; Judges 2:13; 10:6).
- Thinking that God must rescue us if we worship him turns worship into a cheap deal, where God must act to please someone. God deserves obedience and worship because he is God, not for the favors he can do.

1 Samuel 12:11

- As in 1 Samuel 12:9, this list gives examples of some leaders.
- Barak: The Berean Standard Bible follows Greek and Syriac versions, which read "Barak" (see Judges 4:6–24; 5:1, 12, 15). Some translations follow the Hebrew, which reads "Bedan." We are not sure who this judge is.

1 Samuel 12:12

when you saw that Nahash ... was moving against you: Israel's trouble with Nahash likely started before the events described in 1 Samuel 11:1–11 (see 8:5, 20; 10:27).

1 Samuel 12:13

Although the Israelites rejected God as their king, the Lord still granted their request (see study notes on 1 Samuel 8:7 and 8:8).

1 Samuel 12:14

Worship means nothing if it does not lead to obedience.

1 Samuel 12:14–15

To show that Israel still had to keep its covenant (promises between God and his people) even under a monarchy, Samuel used language from the Sinai covenant. This reminded the people that the Lord was always their true king (for example, Exodus 19:5–6; Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 30:11–20).

1 Samuel 12:17

The wheat harvest happened in late spring or early summer when it rarely rained in Israel. Thunder and rain would show God's power as a sign of the people's wrongdoing in asking for a king.

1 Samuel 12:18

greatly feared: See Exodus 19:16 for reference.

1 Samuel 12:19

- The people asked Samuel to pray for them (see also 1 Samuel 7:8) instead of praying themselves, likely because they were not close to God (notice they say "your God" instead of "our God").
- added to all our sins: Their sins included idol worship (1 Samuel 12:21; see study note on 1 Samuel 8:8).

1 Samuel 12:21

worthless ... they are empty: Israel was slow to understand this lesson (for example, Isaiah 40:18–26; 44:9–20).

1 Samuel 12:22

- for the sake of His great name: He always keeps his promises, even if his people do not (see also Isaiah 37:35; 43:25; 48:9–11).
- His people: Israel, are his treasured possession (see Exodus 19:5; Deuteronomy 9:25–29). He will never abandon them (see Romans 11:1–5, 25–32).

1 Samuel 12:23

- I will continue to teach you: Samuel was both a mediator and a teacher.
- Although this speech ended Samuel's political leadership, he continued his spiritual work for a while (for example, 1 Samuel 19:24).

1 Samuel 12:25

swept away: David later used this same Hebrew word for Saul's death (1 Samuel 26:10, "die ... into battle") and for his own possible death at Saul's hands (27:1, "get me"). This warning would continue to apply throughout Israel's history as a monarchy (when it was ruled by kings).

1 Samuel 13:1

- For the kings of Israel and Judah, Scripture usually records their age when they became king and how long they ruled (for example, 2 Samuel 5:4–5; 1 Kings 14:21).
- thirty years old: This age is likely when Saul became king. The Hebrew text and most Greek manuscripts leave out the number, making the original wording unclear.
- reigned over Israel forty-two years: See the textual note in the Berean Standard Bible. The Masoretic Text reads "over Israel two years." Most scholars think something is missing from the original manuscript, probably due to a copying mistake. Most English translations use forty-two based on the approximate number in Acts 13:21.

1 Samuel 13:1–16.13

Saul lost power through three key events, similar to how he gained it (see study note on 1 Samuel 9:1–11:15):

1. He offered the sacrifices himself instead of waiting for Samuel (1 Samuel 13:1–14);
2. he made a hasty oath that endangered Jonathan's life (1 Samuel 14:1–46); and
3. he disobeyed God by not destroying the Amalekites and their possessions (1 Samuel 15:1–35).

1 Samuel 13:2

- Earlier, Saul had used 330,000 troops to fight a weaker enemy (1 Samuel 11:8). Choosing 3,000 special troops here likely does not show overconfidence (compare Joshua 7:3–4). Instead, Saul probably saw the need for a smaller, highly trained elite force to handle the troublesome Philistines (see 1 Samuel 14:52).
- Michmash was in Benjamin, about 3.2 kilometers (2 miles) northwest of Saul's home in Gibeah.

1 Samuel 13:3

- Geba was situated between Jonathan's forces at Gibeah and Saul's forces at Michmash. A deep gorge (a steep, narrow valley) separated Geba and Michmash (see 1 Samuel 13:23; 14:5).
- The ram's horn (shofar in Hebrew) was used to send signals, such as gathering an army (Judges 3:27). For other uses, see Leviticus 25:9; 2 Samuel 6:15; 15:10; 18:16; 20:1; Hosea 5:8; Joel 2:15.
- Non-Israelites often used the term Hebrews in a disrespectful way (see 1 Samuel 14:11; 29:3; see also Genesis 39:14; 43:32). Saul might have used it to bring pride to their identity.

1 Samuel 13:4

- Saul has attacked: The leader often received credit for his soldiers' achievements.
- Saul's kingship was confirmed at Gilgal (1 Samuel 11:15). Now, because of his disobedience, the Lord would reject his kingship there (1 Samuel 13:7–14).

1 Samuel 13:5

- The Israelites were greatly outnumbered, which made them afraid.
- The Philistine army had 3,000 chariots and 6,000 charioteers, showing Israel's weaker position. In 1 Samuel, it never mentions Israel having any chariots (see study note on 1 Samuel 13:19–22).

1 Samuel 13:7

The land of Gad and Gilead stretched along Transjordan, which is the area just east of the Jordan River.

1 Samuel 13:8

seven days for the time appointed by Samuel: This was probably a different instruction from the one in 1 Samuel 10:8. It was likely given on another occasion (see study note on 1 Samuel 10:8).

1 Samuel 13:9

the burnt offering and the peace offerings: These offerings (see Exodus 24:5; 32:6; Numbers 10:10; 15:8; Deuteronomy 27:6–7) were given during important events, whether dangerous or joyful. Usually, only priests made these sacrifices (but see study note on 1 Samuel 13:13).

1 Samuel 13:10

went out to greet him: Saul did not seem to know he had done anything wrong.

1 Samuel 13:11

What have you done?: Samuel's question was a rebuke, not a request for information (compare Genesis 3:13).

1 Samuel 13:12

sought the favor of the LORD: The burnt offering aimed to ask God for victory in battle. Samuel had offered a similar sacrifice, which led to victory (see 1 Samuel 7:7–11). But Samuel, unlike Saul, served in a priestly role.

1 Samuel 13:13

the command that the LORD your God gave you: Other kings offered sacrifices without criticism:

- David (2 Samuel 6:13, 17–18)
- Solomon (1 Kings 3:15; 8:64)
- Ahaz 2 Kings 16:12–13)

Judges like Gideon (Judges 6:26) did the same. This shows that sometimes non-priests could perform sacrifices that pleased the Lord. However, Samuel, God's prophet, had instructed Saul to wait (see study note on 1 Samuel 13:8).

1 Samuel 13:14

A man after His own heart: This prophecy refers to David (see also Acts 13:22) and not to Saul's son Jonathan. Rejecting Saul also meant rejecting his family's rule.

1 Samuel 13:15

about six hundred men Most of the 3,000 troops (1 Samuel 13:2) had left Saul (1 Samuel 13:6–7).

1 Samuel 13:17–18

Armies sent raiding groups to loot and spread fear among their enemies. These raiders went north to Ophrah, west to Beth-horon, and east to Zeboim. They avoided the south because the Israelites were strong there, and the terrain made it hard for forces to move easily (see study note on 1 Samuel 13:23).

1 Samuel 13:19–22

no blacksmith: The Philistines prevented the Israelites from having weapons by controlling all the iron needed to make them. Iron technology was new in Canaan. It likely developed in the Aegean region and was brought to Canaan by seafaring people, like the Philistines.

1 Samuel 13:23

The pass at Michmash was a key route through the canyon, separating Michmash from Geba, Gibeah, and other towns to the south.

1 Samuel 14:1

- bearing his armor: See study note on 1 Samuel 16:21.
- Jonathan did not tell his father because he knew Saul would not approve the dangerous plan. He also knew that Saul did not want anyone, not even his own son, to take honor away from him.

1 Samuel 14:1–15

Jonathan again fought in his father's battles (see also 1 Samuel 13:2–4; 31).

1 Samuel 14:1–52

Saul's actions in this chapter further support his removal as king (1 Samuel 13:8–14; see also 15). Saul was estranged from both Samuel and his brave son Jonathan. 1 Samuel 14 foreshadows Jonathan's important role in the shift from Saul's rule to David's.

1 Samuel 14:2

staying under: Saul does nothing while Jonathan takes action (see also 1 Samuel 22:6).

1 Samuel 14:3

- Ahijah the priest served as an adviser to Saul. He could seek God's guidance for Saul by using the ephod (a sacred garment used to ask God for direction, 1 Samuel 14:18–19; see also 1 Samuel 2:18 and study note on 1 Samuel 2:18; 1 Samuel 23:9–10).
- son of Eli: Saul, the rejected king (1 Samuel 13:13–14), kept a priest from the rejected priesthood with him (1 Samuel 2:27–36).
- Ichabod: See 1 Samuel 4:21.

1 Samuel 14:4–5

The Philistines controlled this area (1 Samuel 13:23), so Jonathan and his armor bearer had to be careful.

1 Samuel 14:6

- uncircumcised men: A word used to show strong dislike or disrespect for Israel's enemies (see also 1 Samuel 17:36; 31:4).
- Perhaps: Jonathan had no promise of survival, but he believed God could give them victory against the odds. Victory depended on God; Jonathan offered himself as a tool for God to use.
- whether by many or by few: Jonathan understood what Gideon had learned long ago (see Judges 7:2–8).

1 Samuel 14:11

- Hebrews: Refer to study note on 1 Samuel 13:3.
- out of the holes in which they were hiding: See 1 Samuel 13:6.

1 Samuel 14:15

- terror struck: This story is similar to Gideon's, showing Jonathan as a judge-like figure (see Judges 7:19–22). God had not officially chosen or specially empowered Jonathan as a leader, but God used him to save his people.
- raiding parties: See the study note on 1 Samuel 13:17–18.

1 Samuel 14:18

Bring ... Israelites: The Greek text of the Septuagint instead reads "Bring the ephod." The ark stayed at Kiriath-jearim for twenty years (1 Samuel 7:2). Unlike the ephod, it was never used to predict the future (see study note on 1 Samuel 2:18).

1 Samuel 14:21–22

Earlier, many Israelites hid because they were afraid (1 Samuel 13:6–7). Some might have joined the Philistine army. The idea that they revolted when they had the chance suggests they might have been prisoners of war, forced to serve the Philistines.

1 Samuel 14:23

- God saved Israel, not Saul. Jonathan acted willingly as the Lord worked through him.
- Beth-aven was directly west of Michmash (see 1 Samuel 13:5). The Israelites made the Philistines retreat all the way to Aijalon that day (see 1 Samuel 14:31).

1 Samuel 14:24

- By making them swear an oath, Saul forced his tired, hungry men to abstain from food. This oath likely aimed to manipulate God for a good outcome, like the pagans might do (see notes on Exodus 23:26; 25:22; 32:4).
- Saul's use of my enemies instead of "our enemies" shows his self-centered pride.

1 Samuel 14:29

brought trouble: Joshua used this word when speaking to Achan (Joshua 7:25), and Jephthah used it with his innocent daughter (Judges 11:35). Saul's foolish promise limited Israel's victory (1 Samuel 14:30) and endangered his son's life (see also Joshua 6:18; 1 Chronicles 2:7).

1 Samuel 14:31

Aijalon: If the Philistines ran away through Beth-horon, the Israelites chased them for about 32 kilometers (nearly 20 miles).

1 Samuel 14:32–34

The men were very hungry, so they ate meat without draining the blood. This act broke God's law (see Leviticus 17:10–14) and was a sin against the Lord. To stop more sin, Saul used a large rock as a field altar to properly drain the animals' blood. This incident happened because of Saul's foolish oath.

1 Samuel 14:35

the first time he had built an altar: This is the only altar mentioned. David later built another altar, which became the site of God's temple (2 Samuel 24:18–25).

1 Samuel 14:37–38

God did not answer: Neither the "no" nor the "yes" answer from the Urim and Thummim appeared.

1 Samuel 14:41

Priests cast sacred lots by using the Urim and Thummim to learn what God wanted them to do (Exodus 28:30; Leviticus 8:8). David also used them to seek God's guidance (1 Samuel 23:2; 30:8; 2 Samuel 2:1). The Urim and Thummim were two small objects, possibly flat stones, sticks, or arrows, used like dice. They would give a positive, neutral, or negative answer.

1 Samuel 14:45

The people, aware of God's blessing on the real hero of the day, were wiser than their king.

1 Samuel 14:47

- assumed (literally took): Samuel often used this verb to describe a king's actions: "He will take ... take ... take" (1 Samuel 8:10–18).
- the Moabites, the Ammonites, the Edomites ... Zobah: David faced these enemies during his reign and expanded Israel's territory (see 2 Samuel 8:1–14).

1 Samuel 14:47–52

Unlike the foolishness mentioned in 1 Samuel 14:1–46, these verses highlight Saul's military victories. Each king's reign in 1 Samuel—2 Kings ends with a similar summary of achievements.

1 Samuel 14:48

defeated the Amalekites: See 1 Samuel 15:1–35. The Amalekites were a nomadic group (people who move from place to place rather than living in one town) in the south. They often attacked Israel by raiding villages and taking goods (see Exodus 17:8–16; Numbers 14:45; Judges 3:13; 6:3, 33; 7:12; 10:12).

1 Samuel 14:49

- sons of Saul were: Saul had another son named Abinadab (1 Samuel 31:2).
- Ishvi: This is another name for Ish-bosheth (which means "man of shame"). He was also called Esh-baal ("man of Baal"). He briefly ruled as a rival king over the northern tribes during David's early years (2 Samuel 2:8–11).

1 Samuel 14:49–51

This information about Saul's family, placed here instead of at the end of his reign, suggests his reign was nearly over and none of his sons would succeed him.

1 Samuel 14:50

Ahinoam is only mentioned in Saul's story here. In 1 Samuel 25:43, David marries a woman named Ahinoam. These might be the same person, but it is unclear (see 2 Samuel 12:8).

1 Samuel 14:52

- Saul easily defeated the Ammonites (1 Samuel 11:11), but he struggled against the Philistines. The Philistines had a strong army and controlled iron and bronze (1 Samuel 13:19–22).
- Saul would enlist him: Samuel had warned earlier that the king would take people and possessions (1 Samuel 8:11).

1 Samuel 15:1–35

After Saul disobeyed God by not completely destroying the Amalekites, God rejected him more strongly than before (see 1 Samuel 13:8–14).

1 Samuel 15:2

LORD of Hosts: See study note on 1 Samuel 1:3.

I witnessed: In the time of Moses, the nation of Amalek lived in southern Judah and the Negev area south of Judah. As Israel traveled to Canaan, the Amalekites attacked the sick, weak, and those at the back of the group. They were the first to attack Israel after the exodus from Egypt, for which God had promised to judge them (Exodus 17:8–16; Deuteronomy 25:17–19).

1 Samuel 15:3

devote to destruction: See "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

1 Samuel 15:4

Telaim: This might be the same as Telem (see Joshua 15:24).

1 Samuel 15:5

The unnamed town in the valley was near a Negev wadi (a dry streambed that fills with water only when it rains).

1 Samuel 15:6

- The Kenites were wandering metalworkers and descendants of the father-in-law of Moses (Judges 1:16).
- You showed kindness: See Exodus 18; Numbers 10:29–32.

1 Samuel 15:7

The area where the Amalekites lived stretched from Havilah in northern Sinai to Shur near the eastern border of Egypt.

1 Samuel 15:8

Agag was likely a descendant of an earlier king with the same name (see Numbers 24:7; compare Esther 3:1).

1 Samuel 15:9

Saul and his men ignored the Lord's order to devote the Amalekites to destruction (1 Samuel 15:3). Even though the whole army disobeyed God's command, Saul was responsible as their leader.

1 Samuel 15:12

- Carmel was a town near Hebron in southern Judah.
- Saul celebrated his achievements by building a monument to himself, but he actually deserved shame (1 Samuel 15:16–19).
- Gilgal: See 1 Samuel 13:4.

1 Samuel 15:13

I have carried out the LORD's instructions: Compare with 1 Samuel 15:3. Saul believed his actions were justified (1 Samuel 15:15; compare with Leviticus 22:19). However, Samuel exposed Saul's false excuse (1 Samuel 15:17–19). Samuel then carried out God's command himself (1 Samuel 15:32–33).

1 Samuel 15:15

Saul blamed the army even though he was the commander. His true motivation was not spiritual (1 Samuel 15:9).

1 Samuel 15:17

As the anointed king of Israel, Saul was responsible for disobeying God. False humility or excuses could not lessen this responsibility.

1 Samuel 15:21

- The troops: Saul kept blaming others (see 1 Samuel 15:15).
- Gilgal was a religious center. Saul tried to use religion to excuse disobeying God.

1 Samuel 15:22

- Does the LORD delight: God values obedience more than ritual acts (see also Psalm 40:6; Hosea 6:6; Matthew 12:7).
- the fat of rams: People offered the best parts of the animal to God.

1 Samuel 15:23

- Rebellion ... and arrogance: These sins of the heart are as bad as the sinful practices of idol-worshipping pagans.
- Scripture condemns witchcraft (see study note on Deuteronomy 18:10).

1 Samuel 15:24

- I feared the people: Saul kept blaming others (see 1 Samuel 15:15, 21).
- obeyed their voice: The chapter does not suggest any pressure from them. Saul's confession seems dishonest (compare with David, 2 Samuel 12:13; Psalm 51).

1 Samuel 15:24–30

Saul admitted his wrongdoing, but it was too late and he still made excuses.

1 Samuel 15:28

Saul soon found out who the other person was (1 Samuel 18:8–9; compare with chapter 16).

1 Samuel 15:29

does not lie or change His mind: Samuel spoke about God's promise to make David king and protect his family line. God had rejected Saul, but he would never reject David (see 2 Samuel 7:8–17).

1 Samuel 15:30

honor me now before the elders: To help Saul maintain his dignity.

1 Samuel 15:35

- The verb phrase mourned usually means grieving over someone's death. Although Saul was still alive, his rule as king was ending. Samuel might have been grieving due to personal attachment to Saul, feeling like he failed, or worrying that Israel's situation would worsen.
- the LORD regretted: See "God's Change of Mind" Theme Note.

1 Samuel 16:1

- How long are you going to mourn: See study note on 1 Samuel 15:35.
- Bethlehem is about five miles south of Jerusalem. It later became known as the City of David (Luke 2:11) and is the birthplace of Jesus.
- Jesse was the grandson of Boaz and Ruth (Ruth 4:22).
- I have selected: This Hebrew verb means God saw one of Jesse's sons and chose him based on what he saw. God, the eternal king, knows better than the people of Israel how to choose a good king to serve the nation. He provided a replacement for Saul who would lead Israel well.

1 Samuel 16:1–23

David replaced Saul as king. David and Saul were alike in these ways:

- Samuel anointed both.
- Neither was pursuing the position of king.
- Both were unlikely choices (Saul was from the smallest tribe, and David was the youngest son).
- They were both good-looking (1 Samuel 9:2; 16:12).
- The Spirit rushed upon each when anointed as king (1 Samuel 10:10; 11:6; 16:13).

The main difference was that David was "a man after [God's] own heart" (1 Samuel 13:14; compare 16:7), while Saul was not.

1 Samuel 16:2

say, 'I have come to sacrifice': God sometimes guides his followers into risky situations. He protects them, sometimes through miracles, sometimes through strategy (compare Exodus 3:18–22). As a priestly judge, Samuel would not have seemed suspicious by offering a sacrifice (see 1 Samuel 10:8).

1 Samuel 16:4

The elders ... trembled: The elders were afraid because news had likely reached Bethlehem that Samuel had rebuked Saul and put Agag to death.

1 Samuel 16:5

- Consecrate yourselves: Self-purification involved bathing and avoiding sexual activity (see Exodus 19:10–15; compare Genesis 35:2–4).
- The sacrifice probably happened the next morning (see Numbers 11:18; Joshua 3:5; 7:13–14).
- Samuel conducted the purification ritual for Jesse and his sons to prepare them for the sacrifice and the anointing of the new king (compare Exodus 19:10; Joshua 3:5).

1 Samuel 16:6–7

- his appearance or height: Like Saul, Eliab, Jesse's oldest son, looked impressive (see 1 Samuel 9:2). But like Saul, God rejected him (see 1 Samuel 15:23). God had chosen someone else to anoint as king.

- the LORD sees the heart: God can give a new heart (see 1 Samuel 10:9), touch hearts (see 10:26), and understand deep motivations (see Psalm 139:1). God sees what people cannot. God sees a person's true character. Eliab's character is revealed in 1 Samuel 17:28.

1 Samuel 16:13

- The Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David, and this was clear in many instances (for example, 1 Samuel 16:23; 17:48–54; 18:5, 12–16). The Spirit of the Lord had also come upon Saul (1 Samuel 10:10) but left him due to his disobedience (1 Samuel 16:14).
- Ramah is Samuel's hometown (1 Samuel 1:1).

1 Samuel 16:14

- the Spirit of the LORD had departed from Saul: This contrasts with David, who received the Spirit (see "The Spirit's Presence" Theme Note).
- The Lord sent a tormenting spirit because of Saul's disobedience (see also 1 Samuel 18:10; 19:9; compare Judges 9:23; Romans 1:28–29).

1 Samuel 16:14–31.13

After God's Spirit left Saul, his rule continued to fail. His time as king ended in shame and military defeat (1 Samuel 31).

1 Samuel 16:18

- harp: The instrument was likely a lyre, a small stringed instrument used for music (as in 1 Samuel 10:5).
- the LORD is with him: People saw that God's Spirit was with David (1 Samuel 16:13).

1 Samuel 16:21

- At first, Saul loved David very much, but this love soon became intense jealousy and hatred (see 1 Samuel 18:8–14).
- An armor bearer in ancient Israel was the personal assistant of a warrior leader (see 1 Samuel 14:1–15; 31:4–6; Judges 9:54; 2 Samuel 18:15).

1 Samuel 16:22

David's father, Jesse (1 Samuel 16:18), made sure David could serve Saul and still take care of his sheep at home (see 1 Samuel 17:14–15).

1 Samuel 16:23

- Saul would become well: David was not just a handsome young man with musical talent. He was the chosen king. David showed what a king should be: someone who brings relief. Later, David wrote many psalms that have provided comfort and relief over the years.
- the spirit of distress would depart from him: Even those who are disobedient and rejected can find relief and comfort through the Lord's servant.

1 Samuel 17:1

- The Philistines were a constant threat during Saul's rule (see 1 Samuel 14:47–52).
- Socoh in Judah was 22.5 kilometers (14 miles) west of Bethlehem, near Philistine land.
- Azekah was a few kilometers northwest of Socoh (the exact location of Ephes-dammim is unknown). The Philistines were invading Israelite territory.

1 Samuel 17:2

The Valley of Elah was a fertile area running east to west, located 24 kilometers (15 miles) southwest of Bethlehem.

1 Samuel 17:4

- champion: In ancient times, opposing forces would sometimes let chosen individuals from each side settle a conflict. This reduced casualties and other costs. This type of combat is shown in 2 Samuel 2:12–17.
- Gath was one of five Philistine cities known for having giants as citizens (2 Samuel 21:15–22).

1 Samuel 17:5–7

Goliath was a huge, fully armored warrior, but he did not have God (a much stronger ally) on his side (1 Samuel 17:45–47).

1 Samuel 17:12

Ephrathite: This means a person from Ephrath, which is another name for Bethlehem (Genesis 35:19; 1 Chronicles 4:4).

1 Samuel 17:15

went back and forth: He worked as a musician and armor bearer for Saul (see 1 Samuel 16:19–23) while also managing his responsibilities at home. This irregular service might explain why Saul did not recognize David during the encounter with Goliath (see 1 Samuel 17:55–58).

1 Samuel 17:26

- What will be done for the man: Compare with 1 Samuel 18:17–27. David wanted a reward, but he was

more focused on stopping Goliath from insulting God (1 Samuel 17:45–47).
- uncircumcised: See study note on 1 Samuel 14:6.

1 Samuel 17:28

Eliab was angry, possibly because he was jealous that David was chosen to be king instead of him (1 Samuel 16:6–13).

1 Samuel 17:32

Your servant will go and fight him: David showed courage, while Saul showed fear (1 Samuel 17:11).

1 Samuel 17:40

- A stream flowed through the valley of Elah (1 Samuel 17:2).
- A sling was a leather pouch with two leather straps. When spun quickly with a stone inside, releasing one strap would launch the stone at a target. David likely became very skilled with a sling as a shepherd, but warriors also used slings (Judges 20:16).

1 Samuel 17:42

- ruddy: The same Hebrew word is translated "red" (Genesis 25:25). Here, it highlights David's youth and inexperience.
- boy: Saul had expressed similar disbelief (1 Samuel 17:33). Goliath, as a champion, expected to face an Israelite warrior of equal status.

1 Samuel 17:43

- a dog: This phrase is a metaphor (a word picture) for a low-status servant who bows and obeys others. Goliath used it to insult David and treat him as worthless (see 2 Samuel 9:8).
- sticks: David had hidden his sling. Goliath could see only David's staff, so he thought David was coming with a simple weapon.
- by his gods: Goliath called on his gods, so David's win would also show God's victory over Dagon, the main god of the Philistines (see 1 Samuel 5:2, 5).

1 Samuel 17:44

A body left for scavengers like birds and wild animals was considered severely cursed (see Deuteronomy 21:23; 28:26).

1 Samuel 17:45–47

the LORD of Hosts: See study note on 1 Samuel 1:3. Even though the Philistines seemed stronger, David understood that Israel had the ultimate advantage with the one true God.

1 Samuel 17:49

- Goliath's forehead was exposed under his very large helmet.
- he fell facedown: The stone only knocked Goliath out; David killed him by cutting off his head (1 Samuel 17:51).

1 Samuel 17:52

- The Israelites chased the Philistines to Gath, which is about 9.7 kilometers (6 miles) west.
- Ekron, a Philistine city, is 8 kilometers (5 miles) north of Gath.
- Shaaraim, a city in Judah, is near Azekah (1 Samuel 17:1).

1 Samuel 17:53

Unless specifically forbidden (for example, 1 Samuel 15:3; Joshua 6:18), winning a battle allowed taking war spoils (Deuteronomy 2:35; Joshua 8:2).

1 Samuel 17:54

Jerusalem became an Israelite city when David captured it from the Jebusites (2 Samuel 5:6–7). Jerusalem was likely where David took Goliath's head after he became king. However, David might have brought it to Jerusalem earlier to scare the non-Israelite residents.

1 Samuel 17:55–58

Considering 1 Samuel 16:14–23, it is surprising that neither Saul nor Abner recognized David. The events in 1 Samuel 17 might have occurred either before or long after David's occasional service mentioned in 1 Samuel 16. Saul likely ruled as king for forty-two years, as noted in 1 Samuel 13:1.

1 Samuel 18:1

- David and Jonathan shared many similarities, both were:
- young and capable,
- military heroes,
- had strong faith in God, and
- had claims to Israel's throne (each had a reason he could become king).

Jonathan's true character showed when he recognized and supported God's choice of David as the next king of Israel (see 1 Samuel 18:3–4; 20:12–17).

- Jonathan loved him as himself: See 1 Samuel 20:17; 2 Samuel 1:26. Others in this chapter are also said to love David:
- all Israel and Judah (1 Samuel 18:16),
- Saul's daughter Michal (1 Samuel 18:20), and

- Saul's servants (1 Samuel 18:22).

Some modern interpreters suggest a romantic relationship between David and Jonathan. However, the biblical text describes their relationship as a deep and loyal friendship.

1 Samuel 18:2

David used to work for Saul part-time (see 1 Samuel 17:15 and study note on 1 Samuel 17:15), but now Saul kept David with him all the time.

1 Samuel 18:3–4

Because Jonathan loved David and knew God had chosen David to be Israel's next king (see 1 Samuel 20:13–17, 30–31; 23:17), he made a serious promise of friendship with him. Jonathan gave David items that showed his status as the king's son and crown prince, symbolically passing his right to be the next king to David.

1 Samuel 18:7

thousands ... tens of thousands: This very large increase in numbers between two lines of Hebrew poetry was a way of making the statement stronger (see Deuteronomy 32:30; Psalm 91:7). Because of his great military victories, David was beginning to become more popular and more successful than Saul (1 Samuel 18:16, 30; 21:11).

1 Samuel 18:8–15

Saul came to view David as a threat rather than an ally and would do anything to get rid of him.

1 Samuel 18:11

In his jealousy and fear, Saul would have been happier with one dead David than with thousands of dead Philistines (18:7).

1 Samuel 18:12

The Lord had departed from Saul as king as punishment for his disobedience. Saul's kingship would fail, and David's would succeed (1 Samuel 18:14).

1 Samuel 18:17

Saul promised his daughter to anyone who could kill Goliath (1 Samuel 17:25; see also Joshua 15:16; Judges 1:12). But he added more risks for David (see also 1 Samuel 18:21, 25).

1 Samuel 18:17–19

Saul offered his older daughter, Merab, to David. But he did not truly intend to give Merab to David.

1 Samuel 18:18

Who am I, and what is my family: This shows humility (see also 2 Samuel 7:18; compare Exodus 3:11). David's family could not pay the bride price to marry the king's daughter (1 Samuel 18:23–25).

1 Samuel 18:19

So: Or But. Either David did not accept the offer, or Saul did not keep his promise.

1 Samuel 18:22

is pleased with you: The same Hebrew word describes Jonathan's love for David (1 Samuel 18:3; 19:1–2). Here, it was completely untrue.

1 Samuel 18:23

A future son-in-law would give a **bride price** (a required gift) to his bride's father (see Genesis 34:12; Exodus 22:16–17).

1 Samuel 18:29

even more afraid: Saul's fear was not justified. Even when Saul treated David as an enemy, David continued to honor Saul as king (see 1 Samuel 24; 26).

1 Samuel 19:4

Jonathan addressed his father as the king to show respect.

1 Samuel 19:6

swore an oath: Breaking a vow is a serious offense against God (see Numbers 30:2; Deuteronomy 23:21–23; compare Ecclesiastes 5:4–5). However, Saul soon ignored his promise and tried to kill David again (1 Samuel 19:9–24).

1 Samuel 19:10

tried to pin him to the wall with his spear: See also 1 Samuel 18:11; 20:33.

1 Samuel 19:11

See Psalm 59:1.

1 Samuel 19:13

- A household idol: The Hebrew word teraphim refers to household idols (small images used in homes,

often for worship or protection). These idols appear in several Old Testament passages, such as Genesis 31:30; Judges 17:5; and 2 Kings 23:24. Having an idol in David and Michal's home might show how common pagan idol worship was among the Israelites. The idol might have belonged to Michal. David did not seem to object to Michal having it. (Compare to Rachel stealing her father's household idols in Genesis 31:19.)
- Siblings Jonathan (1 Samuel 19:1–7) and Michal (19:11–18) saved David from their father and disrupted their father's plans to harm him. Members of Saul's royal family were important in David's rise, though David did not take Saul's throne by force.

1 Samuel 19:18

- Ramah: This was Samuel's hometown (1 Samuel 1:1).
- Naioth was a small village near another Ramah in the region of Benjamin.

1 Samuel 19:20

- Prophets often assembled in groups under a single leader (see 2 Kings 2:15; 4:38; 6:1–7).
- The Spirit of God came upon Saul's men to allow David to escape (1 Samuel 20:1).

1 Samuel 19:21

messengers ... a third time: Each time Saul sent troops, the Spirit captured David's would-be captors. Prophesying distracted them from chasing David.

1 Samuel 19:24

- When Saul tore off his clothes and lay naked (that is, without his royal garments), he unknowingly showed his true spiritual condition. God had stripped him of the kingship. Earlier passages explain this rejection (1 Samuel 13:14; 15:10–11, 23; see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note).
- Is Saul also among the prophets?: In 1 Samuel 10:9–13, Saul was rising as God's chosen king. Here, he is moving downward under the weight of God's rejection.

1 Samuel 20:2–3

Jonathan did not understand his father's plans. David's willingness to swear by the Lord showed he was sure about Saul's intentions.

1 Samuel 20:5

New Moon: The ancient Hebrews used a lunar calendar, and the new moon signaled a new month. They started each month with a special sacrifice (Numbers 28:11–15), which became a monthly festival.

1 Samuel 20:6–7

Israelite families might choose a new moon festival for their yearly family sacrifice (see, for example, 1 Samuel 1:3).

1 Samuel 20:8

- kindness: The Hebrew word *ḥ*esed means faithful love or commitment. It describes faithfulness between people who are bound by a covenant (a binding agreement).
- a covenant: A covenant is a serious and binding agreement that includes promises and loyalty. David and Jonathan made such an agreement with each other (see 1 Samuel 18:3; 20:16).

1 Samuel 20:13

- may the LORD punish me: Jonathan promised David he would keep his promise.
- as He has been with my father: Jonathan saw that God blessed David as God had once blessed his father. The divine favor that made Saul king (1 Samuel 9:14–10:1) would now make David king as Saul's replacement. Jonathan accepted this, even though he was Saul's natural successor.

1 Samuel 20:14–16

loving devotion: The Hebrew word *ḥ*esed refers to loyal love and faithfulness to a covenant (see study note on 1 Samuel 20:8). Jonathan reminded David to keep his commitment to him when David became king. Jonathan's concern was reasonable. In the ancient world, a new king might kill members of the former royal family to remove rivals to the throne. Saul later made a similar request of David (1 Samuel 24:21).

1 Samuel 20:15

cut off your loving devotion from my household: David later cared for Jonathan's son, Mephibosheth, like his own son (2 Samuel 9:1–13).

1 Samuel 20:17

See 1 Samuel 18:3 and 23:16–18.

1 Samuel 20:18–22

Jonathan's plan would allow David to get the message even if there could be no face-to-face meeting. The boy's presence reduced suspicion and gave Jonathan an excuse to go to the field. As it happened, only the boy went with Jonathan to the field. When the boy

left, David could talk to Jonathan directly (1 Samuel 20:40–42).

1 Samuel 20:25

Abner was Saul's cousin and served as commander of Saul's army (1 Samuel 14:50; 17:55). His importance is shown by his position beside the king at this festival.

1 Samuel 20:26–27

- A number of circumstances could render a person ceremonially unclean and thus unfit for attending a sacred festival (see Leviticus 7:2–21). Often, an unclean person was required to be excluded from such functions only until the evening of the same day (Leviticus 15). This explains why Saul became suspicious after David did not arrive the next day.
- Saul referred to David as the son of Jesse (also in 1 Samuel 20:31; 22:7), a description that functioned as David's last name.

1 Samuel 20:29

let me go: This verb also describes how David escaped from Saul earlier (1 Samuel 19:10–12, 17–18).

1 Samuel 20:30

- You son of a perverse and rebellious woman!: This insult was as strong and offensive in Hebrew as it is in English.
- to your own shame: Saul cared about his family's legacy. He saw David's actions as a threat to Jonathan, the rightful heir. To Saul, Jonathan was stupidly hurting and shaming himself by supporting David.

1 Samuel 20:33

- Saul hurled his spear at Jonathan: Saul had tried to kill others in this same way before (see also 1 Samuel 18:11; 19:10).
- so Jonathan knew: Jonathan had been slow to accept the truth about his own father (1 Samuel 20:2–3). Now he could no longer deny it.

1 Samuel 20:41

- David ... bowed: Jonathan had a higher social rank, making David's gesture appropriate.
- he and Jonathan ... wept: For the first time in the story, the text shows that both men openly shared their grief (see 1 Samuel 18:1, 3–4; 20:17).

1 Samuel 20:42

sworn in the name of the LORD: (See 1 Samuel 18:3; 20:15–17; 23:16–18).

1 Samuel 21:1

- Nob was just north of Jerusalem, in southern Benjamin's territory.
- Ahimelech the priest was a descendant of the condemned family of Eli (1 Samuel 14:3; 22:9).
- The elders of Bethlehem were afraid when Samuel suddenly came to their city to anoint David as Saul's replacement (1 Samuel 16:4). A similar fear appears here. In both situations, a well-known person who had problems with Saul arrived without warning. Both Ahimelech and the elders of Bethlehem feared that Saul might accuse them of helping an enemy of the king. Such suspicion could lead to death. In this case, what they feared did happen (see 1 Samuel 22:9–19).

1 Samuel 21:2

"The king has given me a mission,": David lied to hide that he was an outlaw and to ease Ahimelech's concerns.

1 Samuel 21:4

- Only priests could eat the holy bread (see Exodus 25:22–30; Leviticus 24:5–9), and only within sacred areas.
- kept themselves from women: The holy bread was for those who were ceremonially pure. The priest checked that David's men were not ceremonially impure from sexual activity (see Leviticus 15:16–18). Normally, people who were not priests could not eat this bread. The priest made an exception because he saw the men's needs and believed they were on a royal mission.

1 Samuel 21:6

- gave him the consecrated bread: Jesus referred to this event to show that helping people is more important than strict obedience to religious rules (see Matthew 12:1–8; Mark 2:23–28; Luke 6:1–5).
- The Bread of the Presence included twelve loaves, possibly one for each tribe. The priests placed them on a table in the Holy Place. They were replaced every Sabbath (see Exodus 25:30; Leviticus 24:5–9).

1 Samuel 21:7

detained before the LORD: Ahimelech asked God for guidance on behalf of others (1 Samuel 22:15). Because of this, Doeg may have been waiting for an answer to a question he had brought before God.

1 Samuel 21:9

- David used Goliath's sword to cut off the giant's head (1 Samuel 17:51). Both the sword and Goliath's head were taken as war trophies (17:54).
- The ephod mentioned here might not be the priestly garment. Some passages suggest an ephod could also be a statue (Judges 8:27; 18:17).

1 Samuel 21:10–15

Gath, a major Philistine city and the hometown of Goliath, was a clever but dangerous place for David to seek refuge from Saul.

1 Samuel 21:11

king of the land: David's reputation as a powerful warrior had become even greater than King Saul's (see 1 Samuel 18:7). Because of this, people outside Israel began to speak of David as if he were already Israel's king.

1 Samuel 21:12–13

The long title of Psalm 34 mentions this event but calls the Philistine king Abimelech instead of Achish. "Abimelech" might have been a general title for Philistine kings (in Hebrew, it means "my father the king"). The name Abimelech also appears in Genesis 20:2 and 26:1.

1 Samuel 22:1

- Adullam was about 25.8 kilometers (16 miles) southwest of Jerusalem, near Philistine land.
- If David's brothers and other relatives had stayed in Bethlehem, Saul could have easily targeted them for revenge.

1 Samuel 22:1–23

Saul's character is clear here. He could not take revenge on David himself. Instead, Saul killed those he believed had helped David.

1 Samuel 22:2

distressed ... indebted ... discontented: The people who gathered around David were distressed, poor, and unhappy. By drawing such people to himself, David pointed ahead to Jesus, who would later welcome people who were hurting, burdened, and pushed to the edges of society (Matthew 11:25–30).

1 Samuel 22:3–4

- Mizpeh in Moab was east of the Dead Sea and the Jordan River. It was a difficult journey from Adullam, especially if David's 400 men traveled with him (1 Samuel 22:2).
- they stayed with him: Jesse's grandmother, Ruth, was a Moabite (Ruth 4:13–22).

1 Samuel 22:5

The prophet Gad was David's special adviser (2 Samuel 24:11). God had stopped communicating with Saul and was now guiding David.

1 Samuel 22:7–8

men of Benjamin: Saul was suspicious of his own tribesmen. He believed David had paid them to be loyal to him. Worse, Saul did not even trust his own son. He believed his son was part of the supposed conspiracy.

1 Samuel 22:13

David had deceived Ahimelech into thinking he was on a mission from Saul (1 Samuel 21:1–9). Because of this, Saul's accusations of conspiracy had no basis.

1 Samuel 22:14

the king's son-in-law: David had married Saul's daughter (1 Samuel 18:17–29).

1 Samuel 22:18

- Doeg the Edomite ... struck down the priests: Doeg was not an Israelite, so he did not respect the holiness of priests chosen by God. He knew the priests were innocent, yet he still killed them. In this way, Doeg partly fulfilled God's earlier judgment against the priestly family of Eli (see 1 Samuel 2:27–34 and 1 Kings 2:27).
- men who wore the linen ephod: This incident shows how irrational Saul had become. Not even those in sacred office were safe.

1 Samuel 22:19

Saul had been unwilling to carry out God's orders to destroy completely the Amalekites and their possessions (1 Samuel 15:3, 9). Yet now, in his rage, he did not hesitate to destroy the priests' families and their possessions (see Proverbs 14:29; 16:14; 27:4).

1 Samuel 22:20

Abiathar became an adviser to David, providing guidance from the Lord through the ephod (a priestly garment) (1 Samuel 23:2–12; 2 Samuel 15:24–36). Later, he conspired with Adonijah against David and Solomon (1 Kings 1–2).

1 Samuel 23:1

Keilah was near Adullam (1 Samuel 22:1). It was at the western edge of Judah, near the Philistine border (see Joshua 15:44; Nehemiah 3:17–18).

1 Samuel 23:1–29

Because Saul received reports from informants, he was able to continue pursuing David (1 Samuel 23:7,13). David also had informants, which helped him stay ahead of Saul (1 Samuel 23:1, 9, 15, 25). David's greatest advantage was that he could seek guidance and help from God, which Saul did not have (1 Samuel 23:2, 4, 12).

1 Samuel 23:4

David asked the Lord for guidance, either by praying directly or by using the ephod (a priestly garment used to seek God's will), as described in 1 Samuel 23:6, 9; 2 Samuel 2:1; and 2 Samuel 5:23–24. God's answers were a sign of his blessing and protection (compare 1 Samuel 28:6).

1 Samuel 23:6

the ephod: Saul killed 85 priests who wore ephods (1 Samuel 22:18; see study note on 1 Samuel 2:18). However, the priest who escaped had the high priest's ephod, which held the Urim and Thummim (sacred objects used for decision-making).

1 Samuel 23:7

God has delivered him into my hand: This statement is not true. David later explains that Saul's claim is wrong (see 1 Samuel 23:14).

1 Samuel 23:14

- The wilderness strongholds were natural rock formations that offered shelter.
- Ziph was about 16 kilometers (10 miles) southeast of Keilah (1 Samuel 23:1).

1 Samuel 23:16

Jonathan encouraged David because he knew God had chosen David to be king.

1 Samuel 23:17

you will be king ... I will be your second-in-command (literally second to you): Jonathan accepted that God chose David as king and gave up his own ambitions to be king. Jonathan never held an official role in David's court and died in battle with his father (1 Samuel 31:2).

1 Samuel 23:18

- a covenant: See 1 Samuel 18:3–4; 20:12–17.
- Jonathan went home: This was likely the last time David and Jonathan saw each other.

1 Samuel 23:19

- Hakilah was a hill in the wilderness region of Ziph (1 Samuel 23:14).
- Jeshimon is sometimes translated as "wasteland" rather than as a place name. Here, it refers to a specific wasteland north of the Dead Sea, on both banks of the Jordan River (see Numbers 21:20).

1 Samuel 23:20

Keilah (1 Samuel 23:12) and Ziph (23:14; Psalm 54:1) were located in Judah, but neither one provided sanctuary for David, a native of Judah. David's rise to power was not the result of his own tribe's loyalty but because of the will of God.

1 Samuel 23:24

- Maon was about 4.8 kilometers (3 miles) directly south of the wilderness of Ziph (1 Samuel 23:14), about 16 kilometers (10 miles) south of Hebron.
- The Arabah Valley is a deep rift stretching from above the Sea of Galilee down both sides of the Jordan River to the Dead Sea.

1 Samuel 23:28

Sela-hammahlekoth: The Hebrew name is often translated "Rock of Escape." People in ancient Israel often gave place names to remember their thanks to God (for example, Genesis 22:14; 28:19; 32:30). The exact rock formation that received this name is unknown.

1 Samuel 23:29

David traveled eastward from the area of Ziph (1 Samuel 23:14). He found safety in the strongholds of En-gedi. These rocky highlands were on the western shore of the Dead Sea. There was an oasis in this region, making it an ideal place to find water and food.

1 Samuel 24:2

three thousand chosen men: David's force was outnumbered five to one (1 Samuel 23:13).

1 Samuel 24:4

- David's men believed, as Saul did, that if the circumstances seem right, the Lord is telling you through those circumstances what to do (see 1 Samuel 23:7).

- David might have cut a piece of Saul's robe without getting caught because Saul either took off the robe and set it aside or fell asleep in the cave.

1 Samuel 24:5

David felt guilty because he had dishonored God's anointed king.

1 Samuel 24:6

The Lord's anointed one was not to be harmed (1 Samuel 26:9, 11, 16, 23; 2 Samuel 1:14, 16; 19:21). David refused to hurt Saul, even though God had chosen David to be the next king (1 Samuel 16:13).

1 Samuel 24:11

my father: Saul was actually David's father-in-law (1 Samuel 18:27). David was demonstrating his respect for the king and recalling a day when their relationship had been much friendlier.

1 Samuel 24:12

- May the LORD judge: There was no human authority who could decide what was right between Saul and David. Because of this, David asked God to judge the matter (see Genesis 16:5; 31:53; Exodus 5:21; Judges 11:27).
- may the LORD take vengeance on you: David trusted God's plan instead of trying to control it.

1 Samuel 24:13

The proverb shows that David was in the right and that Saul was in the wrong. David refused to do evil, even when he had the chance to kill Saul. Saul, however, repeatedly tried to kill David.

1 Samuel 24:20

I know for sure that you will be king: This was Saul's first open admission of the truth (compare 1 Samuel 23:17).

1 Samuel 24:21–22

swear to me ... you will not cut off my descendants: Having descendants was a way that Saul's name would endure among the living. David had already sworn such an oath with Jonathan (1 Samuel 20:14–17).

1 Samuel 25:1

Paran: According to the Masoretic Text, David went to the wilderness of Paran after Samuel's death. The Septuagint instead reads Maon, which fits better with the following story set in the Maon/Carmel area of Judah. This town in southern Judah (see study note on 1 Samuel 23:24) was probably Nabal's home. The wilderness of Paran itself lay much farther south, in the northern Sinai near Kadesh-barnea, and is elsewhere described as a place of refuge (Genesis 21:21; 1 Kings 11:18).

1 Samuel 25:1–44

This story about Nabal falls between two accounts in which Saul pursued David and David spared Saul's life. Nabal was similar to Saul.

1 Samuel 25:2

Carmel was a village near Maon. It should not be confused with the famous mountain from the story of Elijah in 1 Kings 18. In this village, Saul built a monument to celebrate his victory over the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15:12).

1 Samuel 25:3

- Nabal: See 1 Samuel 25:25 to understand the irony of his name.
- Unlike her husband, Abigail was a sensible and wise person, as the story shows.

1 Samuel 25:8

Sheep-shearing time for herdsmen was like harvest time for farmers. It was a time of celebration and thankfulness for blessings.

1 Samuel 25:10

son of Jesse: This phrase refers to **David**. Like Saul, Nabal used this description in a disrespectful way. He avoided using David's name to show contempt rather than honor (1 Samuel 20:27, 31; 22:7).

1 Samuel 25:21

he has paid me back evil for good: See also 1 Samuel 24:17.

1 Samuel 25:26

the LORD has held you back from bloodshed and from avenging yourself: **Abigail** began her plea by saying that God had kept David from murder and revenge, and she ended it the same way (1 Samuel 25:31). She reminded David that he had the power to kill Nabal, just as he had the power to kill Saul, but he chose not to do so.

1 Samuel 25:28

- a lasting dynasty: God promised David that his family line would continue (see 2 Samuel 7).
- fights the LORD's battles: David was famous and admired for defeating Israel's enemies (1 Samuel 18:7, 13, 16).
- no evil be found in you: This does not mean that David was without sin. It means that he was innocent in the way he pursued the throne. He did not try to seize it by violence, as 1 Samuel 25:29–31 makes clear.

1 Samuel 25:29

The phrase like stones from a sling fits David well. David famously defeated Goliath by striking him with a stone from a sling (1 Samuel 17:32–51). The image reminds listeners of that event and highlights David's strength and skill.

1 Samuel 25:36

for a king: Nabal was like Saul (see study note on 1 Samuel 25:1–44).

1 Samuel 25:37

Nabal was so stunned by the revelation that he had a stroke or a heart attack.

1 Samuel 25:39

- Nabal's death was God's punishment for his sin. David could not be accused of vengeful murder.
- David quickly asked Abigail to marry him. She had proven herself wise and was also beautiful (1 Samuel 25:3).

1 Samuel 25:43

- Ahinoam was also the name of Saul's wife (1 Samuel 14:50). If she was the same woman, then David married Saul's widow after Saul died (1 Samuel 31:1–13). This would create another parallel between Nabal and Saul. However, other passages suggest they were two different women (1 Samuel 27:3; 30:5).
- This Jezreel was a small village in Judah, near Maon, Ziph, and Carmel (Joshua 15:55–56). It was not the better-known northern city of Jezreel.

1 Samuel 25:44

Saul likely gave Michal to another man for political reasons. He wanted to weaken David's claim to the throne by ending David's marriage to a royal family member.

1 Samuel 26:1

- The men from Ziph had earlier offered to capture David and give him to Saul (1 Samuel 23:19–20).
- Hakilah opposite Jeshimon: The same place they had told Saul about before (1 Samuel 23:19). David likely stayed nearby because the hilly area had many caves, which were good for hiding.

1 Samuel 26:1–25

This was the last time Saul and David were together. The Ziphites informed Saul again about David's hiding place (see 1 Samuel 23:19–20). David spared Saul's life again, just like he did in the cave at En-gedi (see 1 Samuel 24).

1 Samuel 26:3

Saul went after David again, even though he had earlier admitted that he was wrong (1 Samuel 24:17–21). By this time, Saul was no longer able to think clearly or speak truthfully.

1 Samuel 26:5

Abner the son of Ner: See study note on 1 Samuel 20:2.

1 Samuel 26:6

- This is the only reference to Ahimelech the Hittite.
- Zeruiah was David's sister (1 Chronicles 2:16), making Abishai David's nephew. Zeruiah's sons (Abishai, Joab, and Asahel) were three of David's most loyal followers (for example, 2 Samuel 2:18). But they sometimes caused him trouble (see 2 Samuel 3:39; 16:10; 19:22).

1 Samuel 26:8

God has delivered your enemy into your hand: Compare 1 Samuel 24:4.

1 Samuel 26:9

the LORD's anointed: See study note on 1 Samuel 24:6.

1 Samuel 26:10

David was confident that God would judge between him and Saul just as he had done between him and Nabal (see 1 Samuel 25:38). Saul died in battle against the Philistines (1 Samuel 31:6).

1 Samuel 26:14

Abner: See study note on 1 Samuel 20:25.

1 Samuel 26:16

deserve to die: Death was the punishment for failing to do one's duty.

1 Samuel 26:17

Is that your voice, David my son?: See 1 Samuel 24:16.

1 Samuel 26:19

- If the LORD has stirred you up against me: David was confused by Saul's actions and worried he might have sinned without knowing.
- if men have done it: This might refer to Doeg (1 Samuel 22:9–10).
- serve other gods: This idea is similar to Psalm 137:4. People exiled from the holy land could not worship the Lord through sacrifices at the main sanctuary.

1 Samuel 26:20

a flea: Compare 1 Samuel 24:14.

1 Samuel 26:21

- I have sinned: Saul had realized his mistakes before (1 Samuel 24:16–19). David had no reason to trust him again (see 1 Samuel 27:1).
- I have played the fool: The Hebrew word used here (sakal) means "to act foolishly" or "to play the fool" (see also 1 Samuel 13:13). This word is different from the word for "fool" (nabal) used in 1 Samuel 25. Even though the words are different, they have similar meanings. This helps show that Saul and Nabal are parallel figures. Both act foolishly and oppose God's purposes.

1 Samuel 26:23

David did not harm Saul (1 Samuel 24:6; 26:9) because Saul was the Lord's anointed one (see study note on 1 Samuel 24:6).

1 Samuel 26:24

As surely as I valued your life today, so may the LORD value my life: David could not rely on Saul to do the same, so he trusted God with his fate.

1 Samuel 26:25

Saul returned home, and this may have been David's last personal encounter with him.

1 Samuel 27:1–12

David fled to the Philistines to get away from Saul for good. Rather than killing Saul, David chose the dangerous life of a fugitive.

1 Samuel 27:2

This was David's second stay with Achish, the Philistine king (see 1 Samuel 21:10–15). On both occasions, David lied to him (see 1 Samuel 27:10).

1 Samuel 27:6

- Ziklag was about 35.4 kilometers (22 miles) southwest of Gath.
- still belongs to the kings of Judah: This note was written after Solomon's death in 931 BC and before the beginning of the Babylonian exile in 586 BC.

1 Samuel 27:8

- the Geshurites, the Girzites, and the Amalekites: These groups lived on the edges of the southern desert and caused problems for both the Philistines and Israelites. (For more on the Amalekites, see 1 Samuel 14:48; 15; for more on the Geshurites, see Joshua 13:2, 13; 2 Samuel 3:3.)
- Shur was somewhere east of Egypt (1 Samuel 15:7; Genesis 16:7; 20:1; 25:18).

1 Samuel 27:9

he did not leave a man or woman alive: At least some of these people were among those whom God had commanded Israel to destroy (see 1 Samuel 15:3; 28:18; Deuteronomy 25:17–19; Joshua 13:13).

1 Samuel 27:10

- David misled Achish by claiming his attacks were against his own people of Judah and two other related groups. The text neither praises nor criticizes David for lying to the foreign king.
- The Jerahmeelites were a Semitic tribe (an ancient people group from the Middle East who shared related languages and customs) living in southern Judah (see 1 Chronicles 2:9, 25–27, 33, 42).
- Kenites: The father-in-law of Moses was a Kenite (see Judges 1:16; 4:11; see also study note on 1 Samuel 15:6).

1 Samuel 28:1

for warfare: Fights between Israel and the Philistines happened often. In exchange for providing refuge, Achish expected David's military involvement and cooperation.

1 Samuel 28:3

had removed ... from the land: Saul had either forced most mediums (people who claimed they could communicate with the spirits of the dead) to leave the land or put them to death. Or he had made necro-

mancy (the practice of trying to speak with the dead) illegal (see study note on 1 Samuel 28:9).

1 Samuel 28:3–14

Saul consulted the dead, a practice forbidden by God's law (see Leviticus 20:27; Deuteronomy 18:9–11).

1 Samuel 28:4

- Shunem was a border town in the land of Issachar (Joshua 19:18). It overlooked the Valley of Jezreel.
- Mount Gilboa is at the east end of the Valley of Jezreel. The mountain got its name from a nearby village.

1 Samuel 28:6

did not answer him: Earlier, Saul had asked the Lord for guidance using sacred lots, but the results were unclear (1 Samuel 14:36–42). God's silence was a sign of his judgment (1 Samuel 14:37; Lamentations 2:9; Ezekiel 7:26; Amos 8:11–12; Micah 3:6–7).

1 Samuel 28:7

- Without God's guidance, Saul turned to forbidden ways to learn God's will. Saul had earlier banned the occult practice that he now used himself (1 Samuel 28:3).
- Endor was on the border between Israel and Philistia. The area near Israel's border was probably a safer location for a banned practice.

1 Samuel 28:9

killed: Literally cut off, suggesting that Saul might have had most of the mediums executed.

1 Samuel 28:12

We do not know why seeing Samuel caused this woman to recognize Saul.

1 Samuel 28:13

Saul asked the medium to describe what she saw that caused her to scream. She described a divine being, a god (Hebrew 'elohim) coming up. erhaps she observed a human figure with a godlike or angelic appearance, or her use of the term god might reflect a pagan belief that a person becomes a god (a spirit possessing supernatural abilities) after death.

1 Samuel 28:15

- God has turned away from me: The same Hebrew term appears in 1 Samuel 16:14 and Judges 16:20.
- no longer answers me, either by prophets or by dreams: Compare 1 Samuel 28:6.

1 Samuel 28:16

Saul's enemy was not David but the Lord himself.

1 Samuel 28:17

torn the kingship out of your hand: See 1 Samuel 15:28.

1 Samuel 28:18

you did not obey: Samuel's message to Saul had not changed (compare 1 Samuel 15:19).

1 Samuel 28:19

will be with me: In Sheol, the place where the dead are believed to dwell (compare 1 Samuel 2:6, to Sheol; see also Numbers 16:30–33; Job 17:1–16; Psalm 49:11; Revelation 1:18).

1 Samuel 28:24

fattened calf ... flour ... and baked unleavened bread: Preparing this meal required much time and effort. It showed generous hospitality (compare Genesis 18:5–7). The meal that the medium shared with Saul recalls the fine meal that Samuel once shared with Saul (1 Samuel 9:22–24). That earlier meal, shared with God's prophet, marked the beginning of Saul's kingship. This later meal, shared with a condemned medium, came shortly before Saul's death.

1 Samuel 29:1

- Aphek was the site of an earlier confrontation between Israel and the Philistines (1 Samuel 4:1).
- Jezreel was about 64.4 kilometers (40 miles) northeast of Aphek.

1 Samuel 29:1–11

God's help saved David from having to fight his own people.

1 Samuel 29:3

- the servant of King Saul of Israel: To Achish, David appeared to be a valuable defector (someone who had left his former king). The other Philistine rulers were suspicious. They feared that David was a spy who planned to attack them from inside their defenses.
- found no fault in him: This was the first of three times Achish defended David (see also 1 Samuel 29:6, 9). However, David had been deceiving Achish the entire time (see 1 Samuel 27:1–12).

1 Samuel 29:4

with the heads of our men: The commanders' fears were justified (compare 1 Samuel 17:51; 18:27).

1 Samuel 29:5

This **song** referred to Philistines whom David had killed (1 Samuel 18:7). Because of this, it is surprising that David was able to find safety among them.

1 Samuel 29:6

- as the LORD: Achish used the unique name of Israel's God to prove his own sincerity.
- no fault in you: This statement was not completely true, but Achish did not realize this (1 Samuel 27:8–12).

1 Samuel 30:1

- Ziklag: See study note on 1 Samuel 27:6.
- The Amalekites might have been striking back because David raided them (1 Samuel 27:8).

1 Samuel 30:2

- There were no soldiers left in Ziklag to protect the women and children. The Amalekites were known for attacking the weak and vulnerable (see Deuteronomy 25:17–18).
- not killed anyone: The Amalekites were not being kind. They found women and children more valuable alive than dead.

1 Samuel 30:5

- Ahinoam: See the study note on 1 Samuel 25:43.
- Abigail: See 1 Samuel 25:3–42.

1 Samuel 30:6

greatly distressed: Saul had used the same expression about himself. When he was **in** deep trouble, Saul turned to necromancy (trying to speak with the dead). This led to disaster (1 Samuel 28:15). David, in contrast, found strength and success in the Lord his God.

1 Samuel 30:7

the ephod: See study notes on 1 Samuel 2:18 and 23:6.

1 Samuel 30:8

Unlike Saul (1 Samuel 28:6), David successfully asked the Lord for guidance (see 1 Samuel 23:9–12; 2 Samuel 2:1; 5:19, 23).

1 Samuel 30:9

Besor was a large stream in Philistine territory. It flowed into the Mediterranean Sea southwest of Gaza.

1 Samuel 30:10

too exhausted: David's men were very tired after traveling for three days (1 Samuel 30:1). They were now chasing the Amalekites without having rested. David did not scold them or force them to keep going without mercy. See 1 Samuel 30:23–25.

1 Samuel 30:11–12

David once received bread when he was very hungry (1 Samuel 21:3–7). He and his men helped this Egyptian man before knowing who he was or if he could assist them.

1 Samuel 30:13

when I fell ill: The Amalekites valued only slaves who were healthy and strong. They considered the others useless and left them behind.

1 Samuel 30:14

The land of Caleb was in the wilderness of Judah, south of Hebron (see Joshua 14:6–15).

1 Samuel 30:17

The total number of Amalekite raiders must have been quite large if 400 young men escaped.

1 Samuel 30:21

he greeted them: David did not scold them for not participating in the battle.

1 Samuel 30:21–31

David generously divided the spoils among those who participated in the battle and those who were too exhausted to take part.

1 Samuel 30:22

They may take them and go: This unkind group wanted to send away those who had not taken part, without giving them any reward.

1 Samuel 30:23

what the LORD has given us: Some of David's men believed their success came from their own military skills. David attributed victory to God and gave him the glory.

1 Samuel 30:24

They will share alike: Compare with Numbers 31:25–47, where Moses divided the plunder of war between those who fought and the rest of the people.

1 Samuel 30:26

his friends, the elders of Judah: David extended his generosity to influential people throughout his own tribal area, possibly to secure their support for him as king.

1 Samuel 30:27–30

The places mentioned here were all in southern Judah. David eventually emerged from this territory as king (see 2 Samuel 2:1–4).

1 Samuel 30:31

David ruled as king over Judah from the city of Hebron for seven and a half years (2 Samuel 2:1–7; 5:5).

1 Samuel 31:1

- The Israelites fled southeast from the Valley of Jezreel (1 Samuel 29:1) to higher and hillier areas. With their chariots, the Philistines had the advantage in the more level valley.
- Mount Gilboa is southwest of the Sea of Galilee, far from the territory of the Philistines.

1 Samuel 31:1–13

While David was in the south successfully fighting the Amalekites (1 Samuel 30), Saul was in the north unsuccessfully fighting the Philistines.

1 Samuel 31:2

Jonathan ... Malkishua: See 1 Samuel 14:49. This is the first mention of Saul's son Abinadab (compare 1 Chronicles 8:33; 9:39).

1 Samuel 31:4

- David had earlier served as an armor bearer (a personal assistant who carried a soldier's weapons) to Saul (1 Samuel 16:21).
- run me through: This is one of many similarities between the death of Abimelech during the time of the judges (Judges 9) and Saul, Israel's first national king (see Judges 9:54). In both stories, a wounded leader asks someone else to kill him rather than die in shame.

1 Samuel 31:8

After a victory, the army would remove items from the dead. They searched the bodies for anything valuable, such as clothing, weapons, or jewelry.

1 Samuel 31:9

In the ancient world, people saw the death of an enemy king as good news. They believed it meant that the enemy's god had been defeated. The Philistines did not realize that their victory would not last and would bring them no real gain. David, the Lord's true anointed king, would soon come to power and defeat the Philistines. Instead of defeating Israel's God, the Philistines were unknowingly carrying out his purpose.

1 Samuel 31:10

- the Ashtoreths: See 1 Samuel 7:3.
- hung his body: This act further humiliated the executed person by denying them a proper burial. It also served as a warning to other potential enemies (see also Genesis 40:19; Deuteronomy 21:21–22; Joshua 10:26; Esther 9:6–14).
- Beth-shan was a short distance east of Mount Gilboa.

1 Samuel 31:11

The people of Jabesh-gilead were repaying a kindness. Earlier, Saul had rescued them from the Ammonites and their king Nahash (1 Samuel 11:1–13). Jabesh-gilead was about nineteen kilometers (twelve miles) southeast of Beth-shan. It lay across the Jordan River.

1 Samuel 31:12

burned the bodies: Cremation was uncommon in the ancient world. The bodies may have been burned because decomposition had already begun.

1 Samuel 31:13

- bones ... Jabesh: This was not where Saul's remains were finally laid to rest (see 2 Samuel 21:12–14).
- The end of 1 Samuel returns Israel's history to the time at the end of Judges, when "Israel had no king." The Philistines were in control again. David had God's anointing but no crown. He had wives but no sons. His connection with the hated Philistines may have put his standing with his own people at risk. David's future would be difficult. Still, it was clear that God was with him.